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THE RISING NEPAL

ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL

Winter session of Parliament commences

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 5

The winter session of the federal parliament commenced on Monday, marking the beginning of the third session for the current House of Representatives and the fifteenth session for the National Assembly at the Federal Parliament Building, New Baneshwor.

Welcoming the Members of Parliament, Devraj Ghimire, Speaker of the House of Representatives, and Ganesh Prasad Timilsina, Chairman of the National Assembly, read out letters received from the Office of the President and the Office of the Prime Minister and Council of Ministers.

During the inaugural meeting of the third session of the House of Representatives, Ghimire conveyed his confidence in the passage of significant number bills. Referring to the issuance of parliamentary regulations in the previous session and the completion of law-making preparations, Speaker Ghimire emphasized addressing public concerns while instructing the government.

Highlighting the importance of unity among political parties on national issues, Speaker Ghimire urged for effective and advanced parliamentary activities, emphasizing the principles of the rule of law, transparency, and accountability. He announced the initiation of a new process with the implementation of the agenda.

During today's House of Representatives meeting, an economic ordinance and an order to remove obstacles were presented. Dr. Prakash Sharan Mahat, Minister of Finance, submitted the 'Economic Procedures and Financial Responsibility (First Amendment) Ordinance, 2023,' which includes provisions for advancing the time period for prior discussions on the government's policies, programmes, and budget.

Additionally, Dhanraj Gurung, Minister of Law, Justice, and Parliamentary Affairs, submitted an order to address obstacles related to extending the period of the Commission for Investigation, Truth and Reconciliation of Disappeared Persons Act, 2014.

The next meeting of the House of Representatives is scheduled for 11 am on Wednesday, February 7.



PHOTO: SUJAN GURUNG/TRN

Lawmakers participating in the first meeting of the winter session of the House of Representatives at New Baneshwor in Kathmandu on Monday.

PM asks party MPs to play strong role in Parliament

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 5



Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has instructed the lawmakers of the party to play a strong role in favour of the public in the Parliament.

Speaking at a meeting of the party's Parliamentary Party held at the PP office of the CPN (Maoist Centre) on Monday morning, the Prime Minister directed the party lawmakers to strongly present the party's policies and the government's work in the parliament.

"Present yourselves according to the party's policies in parliament with good preparation on government's work," said the Prime Minister. "Maximum effort has been made to maintain good governance, social justice, and prosperity. The government has done commendable work for raising such issues strongly in the parliament."

Stating that preparations were being made to bring a result-oriented budget in the upcoming fiscal year, PM Prachanda said the projects below Rs. 30 million should be delegated to lower levels instead of hoarding them at the centre. He stressed the need to march forward by forming a common consensus of coalition.

He said, "We brought the federal republic system. Thus, it is our responsibility to protect and strengthen the system. Therefore, we need to intellectually raise issues to strengthen the system."

Prime Minister said that the government was applying a new approach for the formation of policies, programmes and budget where discussions would be made inclusive and suggestions from the lawmakers and public would be considered.

Stating that the Investigation of Disappeared Persons, Truth and Reconciliation (TRC) bill would be passed in agreement in the coming session, the Prime Minister said, "It would be good for everyone if the TRC bill is passed with consensus."

90% work of Dharahara project complete

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 5

The new Dharahara tower was inaugurated by the then Prime Minister KP Sharma Oli on April 24, 2021, on the eve of the sixth memorial day of the Gorkha earthquake.

However, the construction works on the project have not been completed even almost three years after its hasty inauguration. Reconstruction of the tower had begun since December 27, 2018 with an objective of completing by December 27, 2020.

Over the years, the deadline was extended six times, with the latest deadline expiring on January 16, and it is yet to be completed.

According to the construction company, it will take at least five more months to complete the Dharahara project. The construction company is hopeful to complete it by September this year. As the deadline of the project has already ended, it needs to be extended to complete the remaining works, said engineer Sajan Awal.

"We have demanded extension of the deadline till September. Approximately 90 per cent physical and 99 per cent financial progress have been achieved," he said.

The landscaping work of the rooftop garden of triple basement parking, colour, the works of souvenir shops of the double basement of the new Dharahara tower, and works of a four-storey museum, fixing electricity lines, and other decoration works are now running at the construction site, he said.

The Dharahara project spans over an area of 42 ropanis of land. There will be a garden around the Dharahara with rest space. The complex will have a four-storey museum, colourful fountains, a rooftop garden, souvenir shops and other structures. The triple basement parking will have the capacity to accommodate 400 vehicles and 700 motorcycles.

Engineer Awal said that the preservation works of the remains of old Dharahara and Sundhara have not moved yet.

In the case of preserving the remains of old Dharahara, Awal said, "We are waiting for the decision of the Department of Archaeology (DoA). The department has not provided any instruction yet."



"We are not working on the preservation of remains of old Dharahara and Sundhara, as the Central Level Project Implementation Unit (CLPIU) and DoA have not provided any instruction," he added.

Kosh Nath Adhikari, project director of Central Level Project Implementation Unit (CLPIU), said that the DoA has not approved the design works of CLPIU nor has it given any instruction to preserve the remains of Dharahara.

In the case of Sundhara preservation, locals have demanded that water be supplied to the Sundhara from natural sources but no water source is said to be traced in Tundikhel ground. The water level was found below 40 feet from the surface level, even though it was required to find water source 12 feet below to supply water to Sundhara naturally, he said.

Around 90 to 92 per cent physical works of the new Dharahara project have been completed so far. To extend the deadline, discussions are being held with the concerned authority, he said.

The contract for the reconstruction of Dharahara project was awarded at Rs. 3.48 billion.

A triple basement underground parking has been built at the General Post Office section. The top part of the third floor of the underground parking will be developed as a park having greenery with various facilities like water fountain and stone tap.

The four-storey museum is being built at the Department of Minting of Nepal Rastra Bank. After completing the project works, a printing machine of the Mint Office will be kept for the visitors to observe, according to the construction company.

Nepal sees rising cancer cases, access to equitable treatment needed

BY PALLAV BHUSAL
Kathmandu, Feb. 5

Proper knowledge, skills, and technology can prevent one-third of cancer incidence before its onset, while another one-third can be detected and treated in time, and even if the remaining one-third cannot be cured, the pain caused by this disease can be reduced, and life expectancy extended.

"Cancer is on the rise in Nepal thanks to unhealthy lifestyle. People are exercising less, exposed to toxic air pollution, consuming harmful food and neglecting their health. All these habits contribute to the increase in cancer cases," said Dr. Kapendra Shekhar Amatya, Senior Consultant Surgical Oncologist at the Nepal Cancer Hospital.

According to the World Health Organisation, cancer is a leading cause of death worldwide, accounting for nearly 10 million deaths annually. The most common cancer deaths are from lung, colon and rectum, liver, stomach and breast cancers. Each year, approximately 400,000 children develop cancer.

"Since cancer treatment in later stages is very expensive, many people cannot afford proper treatment due to economic constraints. Therefore, it is crucial to educate people about cancer and create access for early diagnosis of the disease," stressed Amatya.

The multi-year campaign theme for World Cancer Day 2022-2024 is "Close the Care Gap," aiming to emphasise the need for equitable access to healthcare, specifically in cancer prevention, diagnosis, and treatment. This year, the World Cancer Day was marked on Sunday.

He pointed at the negligence of people towards early diagnosis and urged responsible authorities to make it easier for all citizens to receive proper treatment for the disease.

"While there are good hospitals and treatments available for cancer, the issue lies in the accessibility and affordability for patients. Basic treatment in the early stages of cancer is more economical compared to the costs required in later stages," he said.

Education and social awareness play a critical role in the early diagnosis of cancer. Amatya commended the media sector for its efforts in promoting such awareness.

Amatya emphasised that cancer could be avoided through health awareness, regular check-ups, personal and environmental hygiene, proper diet, and a healthy lifestyle. Similarly, if the disease is detected and treated in the early stage, most cancers can be completely cured, contributing to longevity and a humane way of living.

A recent study conducted by the Epidemiology and Disease Control Division, Nepal, has revealed that cancer is responsible for 11.11 per cent of total deaths in Nepal.

Of all the deaths in the country, the study reveals that over 40 per cent are attributed to lung and cervical cancer, with more than 20 thousand new cases reported annually.

In response, the government is actively engaging health workers in all 77 districts through capacity-building initiatives. This strategy aims to enhance early detection and prevention of cancer.

To support cancer victims financially, the government has allocated funds from the Indigent Citizen Drug Treatment Fund, providing up to Rs. 100,000 for drug treatment. Additionally, provincial governments are extending assistance of up to an additional Rs. 100,000.

Efforts to curb tobacco consumption involve the implementation of the Tobacco Products (Control and Regulation) Act, 2068, the Tobacco Products (Control and Regulation) Regulations 2068, and other relevant guidelines.

In a move to prevent cervical cancer, the government is considering incorporating the Human Papillomavirus (HPV) vaccination programme for 9 to 14-year-old girls into the national vaccination initiative. As of 2080 BS, 10,000 girls have received the HPV vaccine. Furthermore, the government has released the Cervical Cancer Prevention Guidelines, 2080, outlining screening and prevention activities.

Every year, 25-30 thousand people suffer from cancer in Nepal, with more than half being women.

Minister Sharma urges Telecom to provide quality services

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 5



Minister for Communication and Information Technology Rekha Sharma has said that Nepal Telecom (NT) should provide quality services to the customers by paying attention to the global scenario.

Addressing the 20th anniversary of Nepal Telecom on Monday, she said NT should emphasise enhancing service quality, controlling income leakage, and expanding the SMS gateway at reasonable rates.

She also urged the NT to expand the 4G service and increase its usage, complete optical fibre plans as soon as possible, and aggressively expand the FTTH business.

Minister Sharma also asked the NT management to do the necessary homework regarding the establishment of infrastructure companies and IT companies as well as the expansion of Namaste Pay business.

Apart from this, she urged NT to control the unproductive expenses and prepare a long-term business plan keeping in mind the current state of the market and future endeavours.

Minister Sharma said that the work of making 19 model telecommunications districts including infrastructure development, service access and service expansion was in progress.

Stating that the international bandwidth service of the Internet has been purchased at a cheap rate this year, she said, "It is time to remember and evaluate the progress of the work plans for improving service delivery and increasing income. It is necessary to identify the need to improve on the shortcomings and move forward unitedly with concrete action plans."

» SEE PAGE 6

BULLION
(Rs. per tola)

Hallmark Gold	: Rs. 101595	▲
Worked Gold	: Rs. 101125	▲
Silver	: Rs. 1192	▲

STOCK

NEPSE	: 2,076.27	▼
Total Amount	: 2,438,058,254.56	▼
No. of Share	: 7,491,303	▼

Consumers' attraction to organic products rising

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Waling, Feb. 5

It has been found that attraction of the people towards the consumption of organic products has increased lately. People's interest in organic food has increased as it has direct health benefits and is also delicious to eat.

In the festival held in Waling of Syangja, earthworm manure, which is considered important for organic farming, has become the centre of attraction. Many people who come to the fair are getting information about the importance and use of the manure. Waling Product Holding Multipurpose Cooperative is commercially producing earthworm manure in Waling Municipality-8.

Yam Bahadur Gurung, chairman of the Cooperative, said that stalls of earthworm manure and local products have been set up at the festival so that there is information for everyone and the number of organic farmers can be increased.

According to him, many people who come to the fair are interested in getting information about the use of manure and its benefits.

He said, "We have used this opportunity for the marketing of earthworm manure.

People who visit the fair are interested in it and seek information."

He said that those who come to the fair also receive importance and get information about local products, which are being protected and promoted by the Cooperative.

Chairman Gurung said that the Cooperative has been working for the protection and promotion of 56 types of local crops. The Cooperative established in the year 2077 BS with the main slogan of "Encouragement of Waling Product Holding, Identification of Waling Residents in Local Products" has been working on organic farming and marketing of products in villages since its inception.

Netra Prasad Subedi, vice-chairman of the organisation, said that the organisation was established with the aim of developing a modern, commercial, sustainable and self-sufficient agricultural sector from an agriculture-based economy to an agro-based industry.

According to the Cooperative, it is increasing its activities by adopting the slogan "From Crop to Plate, from Shed to Lip".

Bhuparaj Bagale, secretary of the Cooperative, said that among the conservation and promotion work of the cooperative, there are five types of paddy, namely Pakhe, Jarneli, Anadi, Kalo Jhinua, Rato Jhinua and local Jhetobudo.

The Cooperative is working to support the farmers by giving seeds and marketing the products produced by the farmers.

The Cooperative has been doing productive work in collaboration with Waling Municipality, United Nations Development Programme (UNDP) and Diyalo Foundation. The 8th edition of Waling Festival, which is being held at the Waling Stadium, will continue till February 11, 2024.



PHOTO: RADHAKRISHNA DUMRE/TRN

Consumers observing organic products in Waling Festival.

PARISIANS VOTE TO HIT SUVS WITH EYE-POPPING PARKING COSTS

AP
Paris, Feb. 5

Parisians voted Sunday to muscle SUVs off the French capital's streets by making them much more expensive to park from fall, the latest leg in a drive by Socialist Mayor Anne Hidalgo to make the host city for this year's Olympic Games greener and friendlier for pedestrians and cyclists.

More than 54% of the votes cast in the low-turnout election supported the measure to triple parking fees for large SUV drivers from out of town to 18 euros ($19.50) per hour in the city's center, according to official results from City Hall. Only 5.7% of the 1.3 million eligible voters cast ballots at the 39 voting stations around the city.

In get-out-the-vote posts on social media, Hidalgo argued that SUVs take up too much space on narrow Parisian streets, are too polluting and "threaten our health and our planet," and cause more traffic accidents than smaller cars. The additional fees will come into force from Sept. 1, Hidalgo said. "The time has come to break with this tendency for cars that are always bigger, taller, wider," she said. "You have the power to take back ownership of our streets."

The cost for non-residents to park SUVs in Paris' central districts, in the arrondissements numbered 1 through 11, would soar to 18 euros ($19.5) per hour for the first two hours, compared to 6 euros per hour for smaller cars.

After that, parking would become increasingly punitive. A six-hour stay with an SUV — enough, say, to take in a show and a restaurant — would cost a whopping 225 euros ($243), compared to 75 euros for smaller vehicles.

BOEING FLAGS POTENTIAL DELAYS

AP
New York, Feb. 5

Boeing reported another problem with fuselages on its 737 jets that might delay deliveries of about 50 aircraft in the latest quality gaff to plague the manufacturer. Boeing Commercial Airplanes CEO Stan Deal said in a letter to Boeing staff seen Monday that a worker at its supplier discovered misdrilled holes in fuselages. Spirit AeroSystems, based in Wichita, Kansas, makes a large part of the fuselages on Boeing Max jets.

"While this potential condition is not an immediate safety issue and all 737s can continue operating safely, we currently believe we will have to perform rework on about 50 undelivered planes," Deal said in the letter to employees share with the media.

The problem was discovered by an employee of the supplier of the fuselages who notified his manager that two holes might have not been drilled according to specifications, Deal said.

Both Boeing and Spirit AeroSystems are facing intense scrutiny over the quality of their work after an Alaska Airlines 737 Max 9 was forced to make an emergency landing on Jan. 5 when a panel called a door plug blew out of the side of the plane shortly after takeoff from Portland, Oregon.

The NTSB is investigating the accident, while the Federal Aviation Administration investigates whether Boeing and its suppliers followed quality-control procedures.

Alaska Airlines and United Airlines, the only other U.S. airline flying the Max 9, reported finding loose hardware in door plugs of other planes they inspected after the accident.

The FAA grounded all Max 9s in the U.S. the day after the blowout. Two weeks later, the agency approved the inspection and maintenance process to return the planes to flying.

Alaska Airlines and United Airlines have begun returning some to service.

Boeing, based in Renton, Washington, said last week it was withdrawing a request for a safety exemption needed to certify a new, smaller model of the 737 Max airliner. Boeing asked federal regulators late last year to allow delivery of its 737 Max 7 airliner to customers even though it does not meet a safety standard designed to prevent part of the engine housing from overheating and breaking off during flight.

Federal Reserve on track to cut rates this year

AP
Washington, Feb.5

Chair Jerome Powell said in an interview broadcast Sunday night that the Federal Reserve remains on track to cut interest rates three times this year, a move that's expected to begin as early as May.

Powell, in an interview recorded Thursday for the CBS news program "60 Minutes," also said the nation's job market and economy are strong, with no sign of a recession on the horizon. "I do think the economy is in a good place," he said, "and there's every reason to think it can get better."

Powell's comments largely echoed remarks he gave at a news conference Wednesday, after the Fed decided to keep its key interest rate steady at about 5.4%, a 22-year high. To fight inflation, the Fed raised its benchmark rate 11 times beginning in March 2022, causing loans for consumers and businesses to become much more expensive.

The Fed chair also reiterated that the central bank's next meeting in March was likely too soon for a rate cut. Most economists think the first cut is likely to come in May or June.

With inflation steadily cooling, nearly all the 19 members of the Fed's policy-setting committee have agreed that cuts in the central bank's key rate will be appropriate this year, Powell said in the "60 Minutes" interview. A reduction in that rate would help lower the cost of mortgages, auto loans, credit cards and other consumer and business borrowing.

In December, Fed officials indicated that they envisioned three rate cuts in 2024, reducing their benchmark rate to about 4.6% by year's end. Powell told "60 Minutes" that that forecast likely still reflected policymakers' views.

As gauged by the Fed's preferred measure, inflation fell to just 2.6% in December compared with 12 months earlier. And in the second half of 2023, inflation was measured at an annual pace of just 2%, matching the Fed's target level, down drastically from a peak of 7.1% in the summer of 2022.

Powell attributed the inflation surge of 2021-2022 to the disruptions of the pandemic, including a shift in spending away from services, like restaurant meals, to goods, like home office furniture and exercise bikes.

At the same time, COVID closed down or slowed factories across the globe, severely disrupting supply chains and causing widespread shortages of goods and components. Both trends, Powell said, accelerated inflation.

At the same time, Powell acknowledged in the interview, the Fed misjudged the duration of the resulting inflation, which it repeatedly suggested would prove short-lived.

As he has before, Powell said the central bank moved too slowly to raise its key rate, which can help slow borrowing and spending. Inflation began spiking in mid-2021 yet the Fed didn't start raising rates until March 2022.

Americans saddled with credit card debt

AP
New York, Feb. 5

While the U.S. economy is broadly healthy, pockets of Americans have run through their savings and run up their credit card balances after battling inflation for more than two years.

Experts worry that members of these groups -- mostly lower- and middle-income Americans, who tend to be renters -- are falling behind on their debts and could face further deterioration of their financial health in the year ahead, particularly those who have recently resumed paying off student loans.

"The U.S. economy is currently performing better than most forecasters expected a year ago, thanks in large part to a resilient consumer," wrote Shernette McLoud, an economist with TD Economics, in a report issued Wednesday. "However, more recently that spending is increasingly being financed by credit cards."

Americans held more than $1.05 trillion on their credit cards in the third quarter of 2023, a record, and a figure certain to grow once the fourth-quarter data is released by Federal Deposit Insurance Corp. next month. A recent report from the credit rating company Moody's showed that credit card delinquency rates and charge-off rates, or the percent of loans that a bank believes will never be repaid, are now well above their 2019 levels and are expected to keep climbing.

These worrisome metrics coincide with the average interest rate on a bank credit card of roughly 21.5%, the highest it's been since the Federal Reserve started tracking the data in 1994.

"Overall, the consumer is credit healthy. However, the reality is that there are starting to be some significant signs of stress," said Silvio Tavares, president and CEO of VantageScore, one of the country's two major credit scoring systems.

Most analyses of Americans' financial health tends to tell a tale of two consumers. On one side are the roughly two-thirds of Americans who own their homes and those who've invested in the stock market and done substantially well. They generally had the savings cushion necessary to weather high inflation. Delinquency rates on single-family homes remain at near historic lows and home prices have continued to climb. But for the rest of America, things are looking rough.

"You have these noticeable pockets of consumers -- mostly middle- and lower-income renters who have not benefitted from the wealth effect of higher housing prices and stock prices -- who are feeling financial stress and that's driving up these delinquency levels. They've been hit very hard by inflation," said Warren Kornfeld, a senior vice president at Moody's, in an interview.

Kornfeld, who co-wrote a report last week looking at the climbing levels of delinquencies, expects them to keep climbing this year. Consumers' financial health could play a big role in the 2024 election. President Joe Biden is running in part on his efforts to bring down costs for U.S. families. Republicans counter that Biden is to blame for higher costs in the first place.

One way to gauge this bifurcation of the American economy is by looking at the results of credit card companies like American Express, Capital One, Discover Financial and Synchrony Financial. The customers of Capital One, Discover Financial and Synchrony have historically been those with lower credit scores, while American Express typically serves the wealthiest and well-to-do.

At Synchrony Bank, the largest issuer of retail co-brand credit cards, the charge-off rate jumped from 3.5% to 5.6% in a year. Meanwhile, roughly 4.7% of Synchrony customers are 30 days or more behind on their bills, which is also up from a year ago.

Discover's customers are carrying $102 billion in balances on their credit cards, up 13% from a year earlier. Meanwhile, the charge-off rates and 30-day delinquency rates have climbed. Executives say they can see the impact of inflation.

"Think about a consumer that makes $50,000 a year," said John Green, Discover's chief financial officer, at an investor conference in December. "When inflation outpaces your wage growth, they're making choices in terms of what they're going to spend, what bill they're going to pay and what they're going to frankly put on their table."

Inflation peaked at 9.1% in June 2022 and is now slightly above 3%. But the costs of many goods and services remains elevated. A loaf of bread that cost $1.54 in December 2020 cost $2.02 at the end of last year, and a gallon of gas has risen from an average of $2.17 to $3.29 in the same timeframe, according to the Bureau of Labor Statistics.

Renters in particular have felt the pinch. The median rent for a property with up to two bedrooms has jumped from $1,424 at the end of 2020 to $1,713 at the end of last year, according to realtor.com. VantageScore's Tavares worries that the recent reintroduction of student loan payments could more acutely impact these customers in their ability to repay their debts.

"Folks are scrambling to pay these obligations that they haven't had to pay in three years, and it's hitting exactly the demographic we are talking about here: the younger folk, less affluent folk," Tavares said.

RK City Centre of Biratnagar set to close trade operation

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Biratnagar, Feb. 5

RK City Centre opened four years ago with an investment of Rs. 1.25 billion in Hatkhola of Biratnagar is about to close and investors are preparing to operate a hospital in the structure built for the Centre.

The 8-story building with a basement area of 50,000 square feet came into operation in February 2020. Apart from the ground floor and the first floor of the City Centre, six floors are being vacated.

The readymade clothes and shoes are put up for sale offering 50 per cent discount. Employees said that there is a daily turnover only of Rs. 5,000 as customers stopped coming.

The management of the City Centre has already sold various items, including kitchenware, furniture, home décor and electronics with a huge discount offer. The swimming pool on the eighth floor and the multiplex cinema hall on the sixth and seventh floors never came into operation, and the restaurant on the top floor of the City Centre has been closed.

RK City Centre began operating in partnership with paediatrician Dr. Subodh Sharma, the owner of RK Children's Hospital, and businessman Sunil Sharma.

Investors said that when a structure built for one purpose failed to do well, they forwarded the scheme of operating a multi-purpose hospital in the structure built for the mall.

> The 8-story building with a basement area of 50,000 square feet came into operation in February 2020. Apart from the ground floor and the first floor of the City Centre, six floors are being vacated.

Investor Sunil Sharma said they have made up their mind to use the same building for a hospital. A commercial mall named Nepal Bazaar was opened at Mahendrachowk, and after its closure, the structure has not been rented out yet. After the Nepal Bazaar in Biratnagar, the RK City Centre is on the verge of shutting down.

Prakash Mundada said that 30 per cent of the shutters of the central mall of Biratnagar are empty. Although RK City Centre and Nepal Bazaar are about to close, Bhatbhateni Super Store is doing good business and a new business complex named New Centurion Mall is under construction. He expressed his belief that Central Mall will return to normal as the situation eases.



PHOTO: NABARAJ KATTEL/TRN

RK City Centre as seen in the picture.

Tamor Corridor construction likely to halt in lack of budget

BY KABIRAJ GHIMIRE
Hile, Feb. 5

Work on the Tamor Corridor is likely to be halted in lack of the required budget.

More than Rs. 580 million, which was allocated for the under-construction Tamor Corridor, has already been spent.

As of the end of Poush (mid-December 2023), Rs. 400 million was disbursed for the construction of the corridor, and more than Rs. 250 million has been spent since mid-December while only Rs. 180 million is left from the allocated budget.

Pradeep Niraula, chief of the Tamor Corridor Project, said that the work is about to be halted in lack of budget.

The contract for blacktopping of 112 kilometres of road section from Mulghat in Dhankuta to Panchthar was awarded in October/November 2022 at a cost of Rs. 4.16 billion.

In the last fiscal year, Rs. 480 million was allocated for the upgrading of this road, but very little budget has been allocated this year although more than Rs. 2 billion was required this year to complete the road, said Niraula.

This is the shortest route to connect not only the eastern hills with the Tarai but also India and China. The corridor, one of the national pride projects, is in the blacktopping stage, but budget deficit is likely to affect its construction this year.

About 30 per cent of work has been accomplished in the 28-kilometre road from Mulghat to Nawakhola section. It has become difficult to pay workers as the government has not allocated the budget as per the agreement, said the construction company.

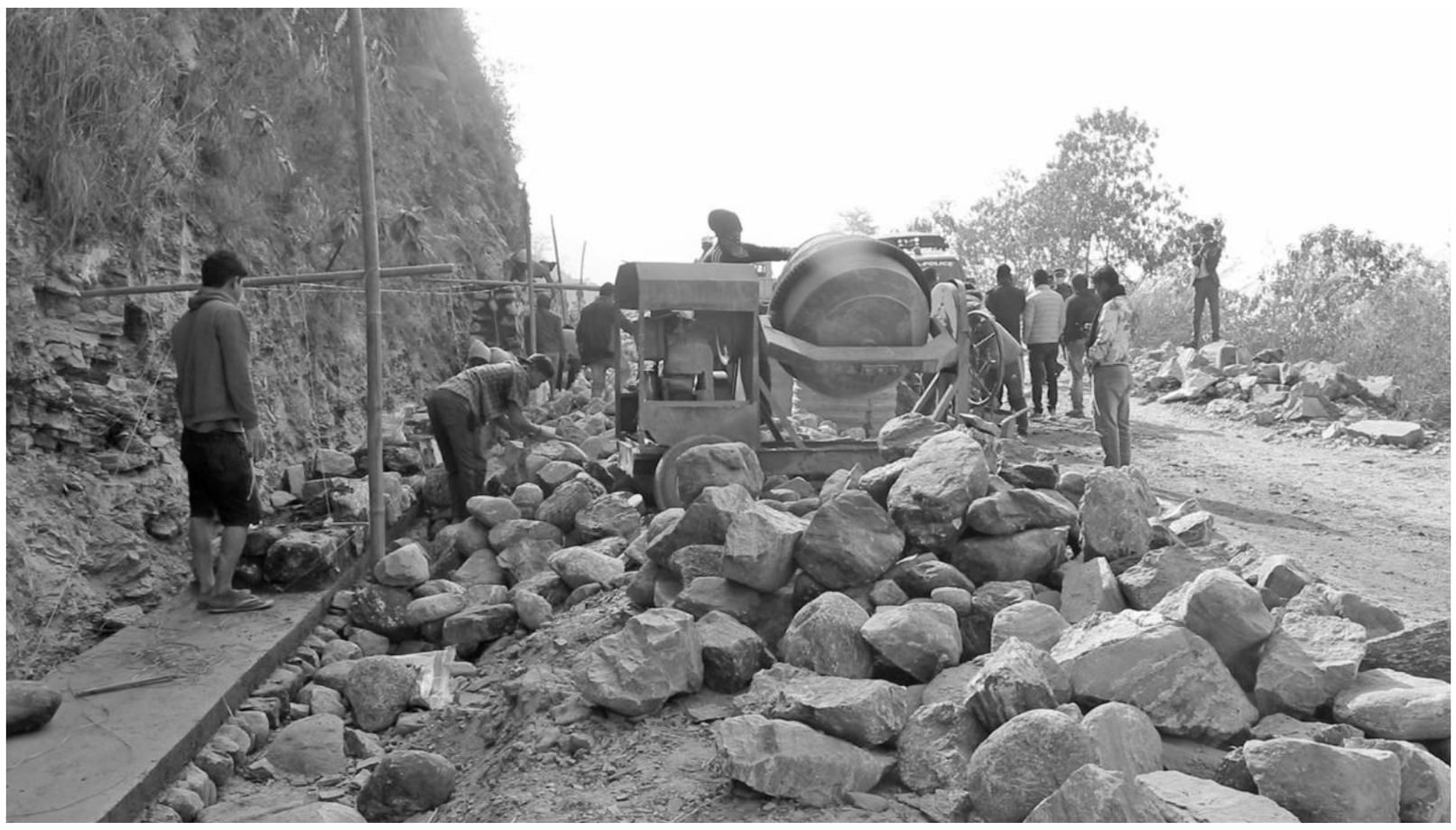


PHOTO: KABIRAJ GHIMIRE\ TRN

Labourers working at under-construction Tamor Corridor road section.

Ajan Dahal, manager of Rautah Kshamadevi Construction Company, said that the work could be halted if the payment was not provided as per the agreement.

District Coordination Chief Niran Tamang said that preparations were made to inform the ministry about the budget shortfall and problems of the project.

The length from Mulghat of Dhankuta to Tamor River is about 180 kilometres and the length of the Rani Customs of Biratnagar bordering India and China border area is 270 kilometres.

Before the opening of the track it took six hours to reach the Tarai via Panchthar and Ilam but after the opening of the track it takes only four hours to reach Tarai.

NEWS BRIEF

Chinese citizen held with illegal money

Kathmandu. A Chinese citizen was arrested with 25,000 US dollars, which she was trying to smuggle to foreign countries.

The arrested Chinese national has been identified as 29-year-old Chu Ping-Sheung. She was arrested by the airport police on Sunday night.

According to the TIA-based security office, she was arrested at the departure hand baggage checking area of Tribhuvan International Airport when she was to fly from Kathmandu to Guangzhou, China, on China Southern's flight

She has been sent to the Department of Revenue Investigation, Harihar Bhawan Pulchowk, Lalitpur for necessary investigation and action.

Mother-in-law daughter-in-law killed

Dadeldhura, Feb 5 Two women were killed due to suffocation while warming beside a fire at Amargadhi-1 in the district Sunday night. They are the mother-in-law and her daughter-in-law.

The two women who slept in the same room had made fire to avoid the cold. It is suspected that they died due to asphyxiation from the burning.

The deceased are 60-year-old Dhauli Devi Diyal and her daughter-in-law Punam Diyal, 26, of Malam, Amargadhi Municipality-1, said Kusum Nayak, the Information Officer at the District Police Office, Dadeldhura.

The two women, who were found in unconscious state, were taken to hospital this morning with the help of their family and relatives. Doctors pronounced them dead on arrival.

(TRN/RSS)

RUBELLA AND MEASLES VACCINES FROM GAVI

RSS
Kathmandu, Feb 5

The government has recently brought 6,050,000 doses of vaccines against measles and rubella.

Dr. Abhiyan Gautam, the chief of the Child Health and Vaccination Section, Department of Health Services, confirmed the arrival of the vaccines in the country under the Global Alliance for Vaccine and Immunisations (GAVI) grant assistance.

The vaccines are manufactured by the Serum Institute of India. According to Dr. Gautam, 280,000 doses of vaccines are awaited.

The government plans to administer the newly arrived vaccines to around 5.7 million children aged under 15 years by launching a nationwide vaccination campaign from February 25 to March 20, bearing in mind the scale of infection risk.

The vaccination campaign will cover children aged nine months to below 15 years in 21 districts including those districts sharing the border with India and assessed as highly vulnerable to the infection as well as the three districts in the Kathmandu Valley, according to Gautam.

In the remaining districts, the vaccines will be given to children aged between nine months and five years.

Adarsha Griha takes care and arranges marriage

BY BASANTA PARAJULI
Bharatpur, Feb. 5



Ashmita Tiwari, brought up at Aadarsha Griha (Ideal Home), a shelter home for children and women at risk of violence and trafficking in Chitwan, tied the nuptial knot on Sunday.

Tiwari, 24, had been living in the centre since she was 14 years old. The centre made arrangements for her marriage to Mani Subedi, a resident of Waling in Syangja district.

According to Tiwari, the centre had taken care of her more than her own family. She said, "My mother died when I was two. After that, my father faced mental instability. I started living with a relative, but due to difficulties living there, I came to this centre at the age of 14."

After living in the centre, Tiwari resumed her school journey.

At present, she is studying bachelor's degree. The groom made a marriage proposal while she was pursuing her bachelor's degree and the centre organised a grand ceremony for the celebration.

At present, 32 women and girls, victims of various social and familial circumstances, are sheltered in the ideal home.

The centre, funded by various sources, has been also providing skill-oriented training to them. To date, it has successfully reintegrated 1,176 women and girls into society, with 46 of them having been married.

Police nab three persons with 285 kg of hashish in Panuati

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 5

Police have arrested three persons with 73 bags of hashish from Panauti of Kavrepalanchok district.

Three persons were arrested with 285 kg of hashish packed in 73 plastic bags of different sizes during a traffic check on the Panauti-Banepa road section of IT Park in Panauti Municipality-5 on Monday morning.

According to a press note issued by the Police Headquarters on Monday, two men and one woman were arrested in the case.

When the police team deployed from the post checked the vehicle, the unprocessed (green that looks like recently cut) ganja was brought in DI vehicle number Ba 6 Ch 296 coming from Panauti to Banepa.

According to the police, initial investigation has shown that the contraband seemed to be brought from the southern area of Kavrepalanchok.

Those arrested were identified as 35-year-old Buddhaman Tamang of Bidur Municipality-11 of Nuwakot, 20-year-old Sanjeev Tamang of Ramechhap-8 and 53-year-old Bimala Tamang.

Kavre traffic fines over 14,000 vehicles

BY KEDAR TIMALSINA
Banepa, Feb. 5

The District Traffic Police Office, Kavrepalanchok, has fined over 14,000 vehicles for violating different traffic rules in the first six months of the current fiscal year.

According to the Traffic Police Office, 14,499 vehicles have been fined for violating traffic rules in the district from mid-July to mid-January of the current fiscal.

Police Inspector Janardan Ghimire, Chief of the District Traffic Police, said that a revenue of Rs. 97.9 million has been collected within the period.

Inspector Ghimire said that looking at the statistics for six months, motorcycles topped the list of traffic violations among other vehicles.

He said that 4,820 motorcycles were fined for violating traffic rules and Rs. 30.2 million revenue was collected from them.

Ghimire said, " Motorcyclists are found committing offences such as not carrying documents like license and Bill Book, not wearing helmets, not following the lane discipline and parking in the no parking area."

Ghimire said that trucks were the second highest traffic rules violators after motorcycles in Kavre.

According to traffic police, in six months, 4,236 trucks were fined and Rs. 3.8 million was collected from the fine imposed on trucks.

Likewise, in six months, 22 people were killed in 93 road accidents in the district.

According to the traffic police, it has been recorded that in the six months of the current fiscal, the highest number of traffic accidents occurred in October. In October alone seven individuals were killed in 36 road accidents in the district.

Nepal Electricity Authority
Distribution and Consumer Services Directorate
Durbar Marga, Kathmandu, Nepal

Invitation for Electronic Bids (Corrected)

(Date of Publication: 05 February 2024)

This is to notify all the concerned bidders that First Date of Notice Publication in the earlier notice published dated 01 February, 2024 shall be applicable as 05 February 2024. Further, the last dates of Bid submission/ opening mentioned in the earlier notice as 18 March 2024, 19 March 2024 & 20 March 2024 has been corrected as 21 March 2024, 22 March 2024 & 26 March 2024 respectively. For Further details, please visit PPMO's e-GP system: www.bolpatra.gov.np/egp.

नोट : प्राविधिक कारणले मिति **05 February, 2024** मा सूचना प्रकाशित नभएकोले प्रकाशित मिति सोही कायम गरी पुनः प्रकाशन गरिएको छ ।

Human encroachment shrinking Sarlahi wetlands

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Sarlahi, FEB. 5



PHOTO: TRN

A wetland of Sarlahi is turning dried due to human encroachment and pollution.

The wetlands in the Sarlahi district are shrinking due to human encroachment and pollution.

The wetlands in the Sarlahi district which play a vital for improving water quality, maintaining surface water flow during dry seasons and providing habitat for aquatic species, and wildlife, are gradually diminishing due to increasing encroachment and human intervention.

Conservation experts express concerns about the increasingly deteriorating condition of wetlands and their surroundings. Wetlands, whether natural or human-made such as ponds, lakes, reservoirs, streams, and rivers, are considered essential to the ecosystem.

According to data from the Division Forest Office in Sarlahi, the district has 1,406 hectares of wetland areas in the form of streams and 422 hectares of ponds and lakes.

However, the construction of the Bagmati Machha Pokhari (Bharat Taal) in 121 bighas of land within Bagmati Municipality has not been included in these figures. Most of the streams in the district, including Barhathwa, are now mostly used for irrigation and domestic purposes.

Other streams dry up quickly except during the rainy season. Assistant Forest Officer Sajan Chaudhary of the Division Forest Office in Sarlahi expressed concern about the deteriorating condition of the wetlands in the district.

He added that several wetland areas, which were once sources of perennial water and habitat for various aquatic species, are now under threat due to encroachment and various other problems. "The majority of wetlands are now under the jurisdiction of local authorities, and it's the responsibility of municipalities to protect them," said Chaudhary.

However, the challenge of conservation is increasing as wetland degradation is on the rise. He expressed concern about encroachment and human interference in wetland areas. Issues such as road construction, building various structures, drying up natural ponds for fish farming and increasing conflicts between humans and wildlife have been observed.

Chandranagar, located within Chandranagar Rural Municipality, which is a major wetland area in the district, has been drying up at a rapid speed. Increased human intervention in wetland areas has affected various species of aquatic plants and animals.

Rohit Poudel, a resident and journalist of Lalbandi Municipality-7, said that the local authorities have been constructing various physical structures including roads near the wetland areas which has led to the shrinking of the wetlands.

Nepal Electricity Authority
Distribution and Consumer Services Directorate
Planning and Technical Services Department
Computerized Billing and Network Division, Durbarmarg, Kathmandu

Invitation for Bids

"Supply and Delivery of Spare Parts of Handheld Meter Reading Devices"
(Contract Identification Number : **NEA/DCSD/PTSD/CBND-080/81-03)**
First Date of Notice Publication : **February 6, 2024**
Please visit official website of PPMO (www.bolpatra.gov.np/egp) for more details

Nepal Electricity Authority
Transmission Directorate
Grid Development Department
132 kV Transmission Line Capacity Upgradation Project
Phone No.: +977 01-4153174, Email: griddev@nea.org.np
Date of Publication : 2080/10/23 (February 06, 2024)

Notice of Intent to Award

IFB: NEA/GDD/TL-080/81-01, "Up-gradation of the existing conductor of Butwal-Sunwal- New Butwal, Damuli-Bharatpur and Kusaha-Duhabi 132kV Transmission Line"
This is to notify that, it is our intention to award the contract for Up-gradation of the existing conductor of Butwal-Sunwal- New Butwal, Damuli-Bharatpur and Kusaha-Duhabi 132kV Transmission Line, IFB No. NEA/GDD/TL-080/81-01 to M/s. Sigma Con. Pvt. Ltd., Kathmandu as their bid price USD 6,447,319.80 (In Word: USD Six Million Four Hundred Forty Seven Thousand Three Hundred Nineteen Rupees Paisa Eighty) and NRs. 107,268,168.00 (In Word: Nepalese Rupees One Hundred Seven Million Two Hundred Sixty Eight Thousand One Hundred Sixty Eight Rupees only) excluding VAT, & Custom Duties as corrected and modified in accordance with the Instructions to Bidders is hereby selected as substantially responsive lowest evaluated bid.

THOUGHT FOR TODAY

Wisdom is oftentimes nearer when we stoop
than when we soar.
- William Wordsworth

EDITORIAL

Provincial Functioning

With the creation of seven provinces on Sept. 20, 2015, and elections for the provincial assemblies (PAs) on Nov. 26 and Dec. 7, 2017, the PAs were created on Feb. 4, 2018. Six years into their formation, there are accusations that provincial governments have failed to live up to the expectations of the people. There are three main reasons hamstringing the federal functioning.

The first is legal. Several provinces have failed to get crucial legislations and policy frameworks needed to properly run a government enacted, making them overly reliant on the federal government even to execute small tasks. This has been a drag on the governments' performance. The Federal Police Act, for example, which is critical to recruit and deploy police personnel as well as to govern police functions, remains stuck in limbo due to disagreements over the authority. The discord between federal and provincial governments on matters such as formulating laws, staffing, fiscal transfers, project selection and implementation, among others, continue to stand in the way of the governance.

The second is political. Because of the lack of outright majority of a single political party, provincial governments are having to form a coalition government, which is itself a weak form of government because of its ineffectiveness in bringing disagreeing factions or parties on board to inject a dose of momentum to major policies and projects and get them done. This has also prevented the governments from taking bold step to get through the bottlenecks holding provinces back.

Koshi province witnessed six chief ministers in the past six years while Bagmati had four CMs over that period. Political parties at the centre have turned the province into a playground to play their power game. When there is quick change of governments, development works suffer. Only a few or no projects in progress is a recipe for mass unemployment, widespread discontent and youth exodus. Such dirty exercises only weaken the spirit of federalism.

The third factor is economic. Even years after the adoption of federalism, the country hasn't been able to liberate itself from the chronic problem of low capital expenditure, which has remained below 10 per cent of the earmarked budget. The problem has now percolated into provincial governments as well. Low capital expenditure starves the market of the money needed to fuel economic growth and bring prosperity.

Provinces are the bedrock of federalism. In order to strengthen it, it is imperative to bolster the provincial governments as well as their coordination with the federal government. The performance of local governments is the barometer of their performance. Through federalism, the country aims to build an egalitarian, inclusive society where rights and opportunities are granted to everyone regardless of their social, economic or religious status. But, disenchanted by the failure to delivery on the promises, anti-federalism forces have been raising their ugly heads time and again.

As the country navigates its journey into federalism, it is grappling with challenges. But what matters the most is to get going with determination, for its ideals are worth pursuing. Enough political will and effective coordination and cooperation between federal, provincial and local governments in the spirit of the constitution is the need of the hour to make the provinces functional and drive the federal system towards realising the constitutional ideals.

Social Status And Mental Health

PALLAV BHUSAL

In the complex tapestry of human life, the influence of socioeconomic status weaves an intricate pattern that extends beyond material well-being. It significantly shapes one's mental health, acting as a silent architect of psychological resilience or vulnerability. The correlation between socioeconomic status and mental health conditions is a subject that merits profound exploration, as it unravels the disparities that exist within the fabric of our society.

At its core, socioeconomic status encompasses an individual's income, education, and occupation. These factors, while seemingly distant from the realm of mental health, intricately intersect to mould the emotional well-being of individuals. Research consistently reveals a compelling relationship between lower socioeconomic status and a higher prevalence of mental health conditions. The question arises: Is this a mere coincidence, or does it underscore a systemic issue demanding our attention?

First and foremost, the stressors associated with lower socioeconomic status can act as potent catalysts for mental health challenges. Financial instability, limited access to quality education and job insecurity create a breeding ground for mental stress. This prolonged exposure to stressors can lead to the development or exacerbation of mental health conditions such as anxiety and depression. The relentless pursuit of basic needs under economic constraints can leave individuals emotionally drained and mentally fragile.

Moreover, the disparities in access to mental health resources deepen the divide. Individuals with lower socioeconomic status often encounter barriers to mental health care, perpetuating a cycle of untreated conditions. Limited financial resources may restrict access to therapy or medication, leaving those in need without the necessary support systems. This stark contrast in mental health care accessibility reinforces the importance of addressing socioeconomic disparities to promote holistic well-being.

Education, another component of socioeconomic status, plays a pivotal role in enhancing mental health. A lack of educational opportunities can restrict individuals from acquiring the skills necessary to navigate life's challenges effectively. This, in turn, can contribute to feelings of helplessness and low self-esteem, acting as precursors to mental health conditions. Recognising the profound impact of education on mental health underscores the need for inclusive educational policies that empower individuals across all socioeconomic strata.

Occupational factor also impacts mental health. Job insecurity, limited career growth prospects, and hostile work environments can heighten stress levels. The demands of the modern workplace can place considerable strain on individuals, and those with fewer resources may find it harder to cope with the pressures, leading to a higher risk of mental health issues.

It requires a holistic approach to deal with the socioeconomic factors that influence mental health. Initiatives aimed at reducing income inequality, enhancing educational opportunities, and improving access to mental health resources can mitigate the disparities. Additionally, destigmatising mental health discussions and promoting awareness can foster a more compassionate society where individuals feel comfortable seeking help without hesitation.

In conclusion, the intricate link between socioeconomic status and mental health conditions highlights the pressing need for societal introspection and action. As we strive for a more equitable future, recognising and addressing these disparities becomes imperative. Only through collective efforts can we weave the interconnected threads that bind socioeconomic status and mental health, thereby creating conditions conducive for every individual to live a life with sound mental health.

Will TRC Bill Be Endorsed ?



Narayan Upadhyay

The winter session of the parliament, which kicked off yesterday (Monday), is expected to address scores of vital but pending bills by efficiently conducting the parliamentary session this time. However, others have questioned the efficiency of parliamentary processes. Despite parliament's critical role in developing a system of governance, there have been questions regarding its ability to perform this function. This is due to chaos and an overemphasis on rituals and formalities that the House follows. As the primary legislative body, it must enact all necessary legislations required for smoothly running the affairs of the state. Unfortunately, this effort is hampered by chaotic meetings, intentional disruptions, and a lack of quorum, both in full sessions and committee meetings.

In many previous sessions, the attendance book showed a large presence but many seats in the House remained vacant as lawmakers prioritise to getting allowances instead of fulfilling their responsibilities. After receiving harsh criticism for rendering legislative sessions ineffective, political parties and their members, as well as the parliament chair, have committed to making the current session more efficient by facilitating discussions on crucial bills and then ensuring their passage.

Conundrum

Among the most essential bills are those pertaining to civil service, education, adjustment of police forces into provincial units, and, most notably, transitional justice, which includes the Bill to amend the Enforced Disappearances Inquiry, Truth and Reconciliation Commission (TRC) Act, which will be introduced in March 2023. It is apparent that the TRC Bill that contains the provision of Commission For Investigation of Enforced Disappearances of Persons (CIEDP) and Truth and Reconciliation Commission has created a conundrum for political parties seeking to conclude the remaining part of lingering peace process, which is a key component of the Comprehensive Peace Agreement signed on November 21, 2006 between the then government and CPN-Maoist Party. Earlier CIEDP had received around 64000 insurgency-related complaints from conflict victims and affected families.

Meanwhile, the TRC Bill, which has gathered dust for nearly two decades, has been stalled due to various contentious issues in it. The most problematic issue is the categorisation of human right violations, which has divided human rights abuses into various categories with varying repercussions. Cruel murder, rape, enforced disappearances, and torture were among the worst abuses deemed serious form of human right violations. Special courts would prosecute those who committed such crimes. Murder, abduction, and other less serious human rights offences may be eligible for amnesty depending on their severity.

The bill expanded reparations eligibility for previously excluded victims and ensured that family of "disappeared" individuals could inherit property. According to legal experts, the bill's most contentious provisions were amnesty and accountability that offers amnesty for some "human rights violations." Critics argued that these provisions have protected offenders from accountability and violated international law. It is worth noting that this bill was not approved by parliament due to concerns about the amnesty provisions and a lack of consensus among political parties.

> According to legal experts, the bill's most contentious provisions were amnesty and accountability that offers amnesty for some "human rights violations."

Meanwhile, Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal Prachanda, who also serves as the CPN-Maoist Centre chair, appears to be determined to get all major parties to support the TRC bill. This is evident, given that he has met with the major opposition chairman, KP Sharma Oli, multiple times to discuss the bill's passage during the winter session. The crucial bill would exonerate numerous Maoists from accusations of participating in several serious deeds during the decade-long insurgency (1996-2006), which claimed the lives of around 17000 innocent people. Many top and lower-level Maoist leaders are currently facing legal punishment for their actions during the insurgency period.

Despite multiple rounds of talks between Prachanda and Oli, no definite resolution on this issue has been obtained thus far, as the main opposition has maintained its position on a few key elements in the legislation. The opposition has argued that the bill should focus on victims, while those who violate human rights should face legal consequences. It should also be noted that the country's Supreme Court has adopted a number of positions on TRC-related topics, including aggressively resolving legal objections and controversies. Notably, the Supreme Court has ruled that amnesty for major human rights violations committed during the conflict is not granted. It is clear in its opinion that the TRC Bill must be consistent with international standards.

Experts believe that the Supreme Court's concerns concerning accountability and justice for victims should not be neglected. The main opposition chair is considered as determined to break the present five-party coalition, and he is also opposed to Madhav Kumar Nepal, the CPN-Unified Socialist chair, becoming the next prime minister. The three parties — Nepali Congress, Maoist Centre, and Unified Socialist — have reached an agreement under which the leaders of the three parties will become Prime Ministers on a rotating basis. After Prachanda's two-year term as PM expires in December 2024, Nepal will be the next Prime Minister for a year, followed by Congress President Deuba for the remaining two years till the next election.

Some speculate that Oli will go to any extent to prevent his rival Nepal from becoming Prime Minister. As a result, he can join forces with Prachanda at the cost of present coalition and allow him to continue as Prime Minister for the rest of entire five-year period. For this, Oli can offer endorsement, allowing the government to bring the contentious TRC bill to light. However, given the pledge from PM Prachanda and the major leaders of the ruling coalition that the coalition would remain intact for all five years, the partnership appears to be in place till the end of the current parliament's five-year tenure.

The current session of parliament will undoubtedly provide us with some exciting events, as many people will be watching with bated breath to see how legislators from both sides of the aisle will deal with the TRC and other crucial bills.

(The author is former managing editor of this daily.)

Wetlands Are Not Wastelands



Uttam Maharjan

Nepal is rich in wetlands. According to the National Wetland Policy 2012, wetlands are water bodies originating from underground sources of water or rainfall. They are swampy areas with flowing or stagnant water - fresh, brackish or salt. They may be natural or artificial and permanent or temporary. Wetlands are in the form of marshy lands, riverine floodplains, lakes, ponds, water storage areas, farmlands or tidal flats. In Nepal, wetlands are categorised as rivers, lakes, ponds, reservoirs, marshy lands and irrigated paddy fields. The country has 242 wetlands, which range from the Himalayan region through the hilly region to the Terai belt. There are 19 types of natural and 10 types of artificial wetlands in the country. The wetlands cover 819,277 hectares of the total land.

The Convention on Wetlands, popularly called the Ramsar Convention, was adopted in Ramsar, Iran in 1971. As per the Convention, wetlands are areas of marsh, fen, peatlands and water, natural or artificial, permanent or temporary, where the water is static or flowing, fresh, briny or salty, including areas of water logging made by man like paddy fields, the depth of which at low tides does not exceed six metres.

Ecological considerations.

The Convention aims at conserving wetlands across the world for ecological and other considerations. Oldest among the modern global intergovernmental environmental agreements, the Convention provides a framework for national action and international cooperation for the conservation of wetlands and for the prudent use of resources generated by wetlands. Nepal signed the Ramsar Convention in 1988.

There are 171 countries as contracting parties to the Convention and there are 2,394 wetlands designated as Ramsar Sites. These wetlands of international importance cover 253,900,552 hectares in area. Nepal boasts ten Ramsar sites covering 60,651 hectares. They are Phoksunde Wetland (Shey Phoksunde National Park), Koshi Tappu Wildlife Reserve, Jagadishpur Reservoir, Gosaikunda Wetland, Gokyo Wetland Series, Ghodaghodi Lake Area, Beeshazar and Associated Lakes, Mai Pokhari, Rara Lake and Lake Cluster of Pokhara (a cluster of nine lakes).

Wetlands have ecological, cultural, religious, recreational and touristic significance. They serve as a habitat for many species of flora and fauna. They also abound in many threatened and endangered species. They are also important for migratory birds, aquatic animals and wild animals. Some birds migrate to Nepal from as far away as Cyprus and Siberia. The wetlands are home to 230 indigenous species of fish, 102 species of phytoplankton, 109 species of molluscs and 117 species of amphibians. Likewise, the wetlands shelter 27 per cent of nationally threatened species of birds, 85 per cent of indigenous vertebrates and 24 per cent of nationally protected plants.

The wetlands are ideal places for tourists – both domestic and foreign. Nature lovers prefer to visit the wetlands, where they can enjoy themselves in a tranquil environment. By managing the wetlands properly, the flow of tourists to them can be increased. In a cash-strapped country like ours, additional income from the tourism industry can be generated. This will further support tourism entrepreneurs and generate employment opportunities benefitting local communities.

> The Wetland Policy of Nepal is designed to conserve wetlands scattered throughout the country by enlisting the participation of local communities.

Wetlands have various benefits to offer to both man and the environment. They regulate water and water supply, purify stagnant water, recharge groundwater, control soil erosion and floods, play a role in waste management, act as an atmospheric, biological and climate regulator and contribute to soil formation, nutrient recycling or retention and pollination. They also support the food web system and are also sources of genetic resources. They can also sustain biodiversity and agro-biodiversity. Furthermore, most rural communities in Nepal depend on wetlands for their livelihoods. Majhi Jalari, Tharu and Mallah communities, for example, are dependent on the wetlands. Fishing, hunting and irrigation are some of the benefits wetlands provide for such communities.

In recent times, the wetlands are facing a threat to their existence. Haphazard hunting, growing urbanisation, expansion of human settlements, encroachment, drainage for agricultural purposes and the like are factors that are degrading the wetlands in Nepal. Development works are also responsible for the degradation of the wetlands. Development has both good and bad aspects. But development works should be carried out taking environmental factors into consideration. It is reported that 5.41 per cent of the wetlands have been converted into croplands. Introduction of exotic species of plants, siltation and haphazard use of wetland resources are the other reasons for the degradation of the wetlands.

Participatory approach

The Wetland Policy of Nepal is designed to conserve wetlands scattered throughout the country by enlisting the participation of local communities. The Policy also accentuates the judicious use of wetland resources. From ecological and other viewpoints, the conservation of wetlands is of paramount importance. The wetlands can be better conserved if the local communities are directly involved in it. For this, the capacity of such communities need to be enhanced. A participatory approach to the conservation of wetlands is needed.

Moreover, the government should embark upon an awareness campaign on the conservation of wetlands as well as on the sustainable use of wetland resources. The government should also document the wetlands scattered throughout the country. Such records will enable policymakers to draw up appropriate strategies for the conservation of the wetlands. Weak laws may be responsible for the wetlands being encroached upon. So the government should frame strong laws so as to discourage or prevent encroachment on the wetlands. After all, wetlands are not wastelands. It is our duty to conserve them for our posterity. So the government, local communities and other stakeholders should act in tandem to conserve the wetlands for ecological and other benefits.

(Maharjan has been regularly writing on contemporary issues for this daily since 2000.)

50 YEARS AGO

THE RISING NEPAL

February 6, 1974

US Oil Company Cuts Gasoline Price

Washington, Feb. 5: A United States Oil Company has announced a drop in the price of gasoline, the first since the start of the Arab

NOTICE TO CONTRIBUTORS

TRN welcomes articles, letters and comments from our valued readers and contributors.
Please email your contributions to:

trnfeatures@hotmail.com
trnfeatures@gmail.com

Or send them to
P.O. Box 23, Kathmandu, Nepal

READER'S MAIL

Boost Agriculture Production



This is in reference to a news report *'Govt focused to boost agricultural production'* published in your daily on Sunday. As per the report, Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has said that the government was focused on bringing increment of production and creation of employment through the development of agriculture sector.

The PM stressed on the development of industries based on agriculture while speaking at a programme in Sindhuli district recently. Agriculture must be modernised and systematised by using new agricultural tools and technology.

The country should set up chemical fertiliser factory as fertiliser is an important input to enahcne the agriculture production. The government has to adopt effective strategy to commercialise the agro sector so as to attain self-reliance in food.

Pratik Shrestha
New Baneshwor, Kathmandu

TAILPIECE

A mother mouse and a baby mouse are walking along when, all of a sudden, a cat attacks them. The mother mouse goes, "BARK!!" and the cat runs away.

"See?" says the mother mouse to her baby, "how important it is for you to learn a foreign language?"

+++++

Every Wednesday night at St. Rocco's Catholic Church is a marriage seminar for husbands.

One night Father Gill asked Fabio to share his secrets for staying happily married for almost 50 years.

Fabio explained that he'd tried to treat his wife nice, buy her a few things, and best of all, he took her to Rome for their 25th anniversary.

Father Gill asked, "So what are you going to do for your 50th?"

Fabio proudly answered, "I'm gonna go pick her up!"

Senegal's House to debate election delay as police disperse protests

AFP
Dakar, Feb. 5



PHOTO: AFP

Opposition supporters walk next to a burning barricade during demonstrations called by the opposition parties in Dakar on February 4, 2024.

Security forces used tear gas to disperse an opposition rally outside Senegal's parliament on Monday as lawmakers gathered to consider the postponement of presidential elections announced by President Macky Sall, a move that has plunged the country into crisis.

Armoured police fired tear gas in an attempt to disperse around 100 people who had gathered outside parliament in Dakar, according to Reuters and AFP reporters.

The tense parliamentary session follows a day of violent street protests in the Senegalese capital – during which at least one senior opposition figure was arrested – and amid growing international concern.

On Sunday, the government ordered a private television broadcaster off the air for "incitement to violence" over its coverage of the protests, another sign of the mounting political tension in the country.

Opposition leaders have used the term "constitutional coup" to describe the current situation, which they say is an assault on democracy.

Given the political row that Sall's decision has caused and the street protests on Sunday, the proposal does not appear to be a done deal.

Sall said Saturday he delayed the vote because of a dispute between the National Assembly and the Constitutional Court over the rejection of candidates.

"I will begin an open national dialogue to bring together the conditions for a free, transparent and inclusive election," Sall added, without giving a new date.

The dispute Sall blamed for the delay to the election arose out of the decision by the Constitutional Court to exclude Karim Wade, son of former president Abdoulaye Wade, from running for the presidency.

He was barred because he allegedly also holds French citizenship – a decision he denounced as "scandalous".

Wade's supporters in the National Assembly called for a parliamentary inquiry into the partiality of two judges on the Constitutional Court.

To the surprise of some observers, members of Sall's party were among those who voted for its passage on January 30.

Sall had designated Prime Minister Amadou Ba from his party as his would-be successor, but with the party split over his candidacy, he faced possible defeat at the ballot box.

Wade is not the only candidate the Constitutional Court has excluded from the vote.

Also barred from running is firebrand anti-establishment figure Ousmane Sonko, who has been jailed since July 2023.

His surrogate, Bassirou Diomaye Faye, has been approved to run and emerged as a credible contender to win – a nightmare scenario for the president's camp.

The international community has reacted with concern to Sall's decision to put off the vote.

El Salvador's Bukele heads for re-election as president

AP
San Salvador, El Salvador, Feb. 5

Voters in El Salvador appeared to give Nayib Bukele a second term as president, putting him well on his way to a landslide victory in an election that for many hinged on the tradeoff of curtailed civil liberties for security in a country once terrorised by gangs.

The Supreme Electoral Tribunal said late Sunday that with ballots from 31% of polling places tallied, Bukele had 83% of the vote, far ahead of his nearest competitor's 7% for the leftist Farabundo Martí National Liberation Front. The electoral site updating the count crashed shortly before midnight.

After casting his vote, Bukele made clear that he expects the newly elected Legislative Assembly to continue extending the special powers he has enjoyed since March 2022 to combat the gangs.

Later, standing on the balcony of the National Palace, he said that the country had made history.

"Why are there so many eyes on a small (Latin) American country?" he asked thousands of supporters. "They're afraid of the power of example."

"Salvadorans have given the example to the entire world that any problem can be solved if there is the will to do it," he said.

The self-described "world's coolest dictator" appeared to sweep to victory after enjoying soaring approval ratings and virtually no competition. That came despite concerns that Bukele's government has slowly chipped away at checks and balances in his first term and accusations that he dodged a constitutional ban on re-election.

After voting, he jousted with reporters, asserting that the election's results would serve as a "referendum" on what his administration has done.

Bukele has been a highly popular leader and only more so since the government began its crackdown on the country's feared gangs.

Under a "state of emergency" approved in March 2022, the government has arrested more than 76,000 people — more than 1% of the Central American nation's population. The asault on the gangs has spurred accusations of widespread human rights abuses and a lack of due process, but violence has plummeted in a country known just a few years ago as one of the most dangerous in the world.

Sara Leon, 48, was among throngs of people who flocked to El Salvador's previously gang-controlled downtown to celebrate. When she was 23, Leon risked her life to migrate from El Salvador to the United States with her 6-year-old daughter.

She returned to her homeland in October because of the "state of emergency." She said she now plans to buy a home here and hopes her daughter who has since moved to Toronto will be able to return.

Bukele's popularity has also drawn eyes from across the region, and he and party are increasingly looked to as a case study for a wider global rise in authoritarianism.

Throughout his presidency, Bukele has been accused of taking undemocratic steps that concentrated power in his hands, something observers have worried will only grow with Sunday's election.

At least 6 Kurdish fighters killed in Syrian



PHOTO: AP

RAF Typhoon FGR4 aircraft returning to the base, following strikes against Houthi targets in Yemen.

AP
Beirut, Feb. 5

A drone attack on a base housing U.S. troops in eastern Syria killed six allied Kurdish fighters late Sunday, in the first significant attack in Syria or Iraq since the U.S. launched retaliatory strikes over the weekend against Iran-backed militias that have been targeting its forces in the region.

The U.S.-backed, Kurdish-led Syrian Democratic Forces said Monday the attack hit a training ground at al-Omar base in Syria's eastern province of Deir el-Zour, where the forces' commando units are trained. No casualties were reported among U.S. troops.

An umbrella group of Iran-backed Iraqi militias, dubbed the Islamic Resistance in Iraq, released a video claiming responsibility for the attack and showing them launching a drone from an unspecified location.

In late January, a drone attack by the same group killed three U.S. troops and wounded dozens more at a desert base in Jordan.

The U.S. military launched dozens of retaliatory strikes targeting Iran-backed militant groups in western Iraq and eastern Syria and also struck the Houthis in Yemen.

The SDF initially accused "Syrian regime-backed mercenaries" of carrying out Sunday's attack but in a second statement blamed "Iran-backed militias" after investigating the attack.

The umbrella group has launched dozens of drone attacks on U.S. military bases and troops in Iraq and Syria, and has called for the withdrawal of American soldiers from both countries.

The attack comes as tensions flare across the Middle East amid the Israel-Hamas war, which was sparked by Hamas' rampage in southern Israel on Oct. 7.

Shelling kills at least 28 in Russian-occupied Ukraine

AFP
Kyiv, Feb. 5



PHOTO: AP

Russian Emergency Ministry employees work at the side of a collapsed bakery after an attack of Ukrainian troops, that Russian officials in Luhansk said was conducted by Ukrainian forces, in Lysychansk, Russian-controlled Luhansk region, eastern Ukraine.

Ukrainian shelling killed at least 28 people at a bakery in the Russian-occupied city of Lysychansk, Moscow-installed officials said.

At least one child was among the dead Saturday, local leader Leonid Pasechnik wrote in a statement on Telegram. A further 10 people were rescued from under the rubble by emergency services, he said.

Ukrainian officials in Kyiv did not comment on the incident.

Both Moscow and Kyiv have increasingly relied on longer-range attacks this winter amid largely unchanged positions on the 1,500-kilometer front line in the nearly 2-year-old war.

However, Ukrainian forces have come under intense Russian attack over the past 24 hours, with continuous assaults along the front line, Ukraine's General Staff said in a statement Sunday.

Fighting has been particularly fierce in the eastern city of Avdiivka, where Moscow is attempting to encircle Kyiv's troops, while Ukrainian forces have also been on the defensive in Kupiansk, Lyman, Bakhmut and Zaporizhzhia, officials said.

One civilian was killed and two injured in a Russian artillery strike in the frontline town of Toretsk, less than 30 kilometres from Bakhmut, said Donetsk regional governor Vadym Filashkin.

The military administration for Ukraine's northern Sumy region said Sunday that Russian forces had shelled the region in 16 separate attacks the previous day, firing on the border communities of Yunakivka, Bilopillia, Krasnopillia, Velyka Pysarivka, and Esman. Gen. Serhii Naiev, commander of the Ukrainian Joint Forces, also said that Kyiv's troops had pushed back Russian sabotage and reconnaissance units attempting to cross the border in the Sumy region.

With Ukraine's soldiers concentrated in the eastern regions of Donetsk, Zaporizhzhia and Kharkiv, the reported incursion suggests that Moscow could be probing vulnerabilities on a new front to further stretch Ukrainian resources.

PRISM

Unclaimed emu gets new sanctuary home

Washington: An emu found wandering loose in Washington has a new home at a sanctuary after no owner came forward to claim the large Australian bird.

The Kitsap Humane Society said the emu, nicknamed Elliot, was captured last week with help from the Washington State Patrol, the Kitsap County Sheriff's Office and the Washington State Department of Transportation.

The emu was taken to a barn temporarily while investigators tried to find its owner.

The flightless bird went unclaimed for more than 72 hours, leading the humane society to find it a new permanent home at the Centre Valley Animal Rescue.

Pigeon freed in after being cleared of spying

Mumbai: A pigeon was released by police in India after being detained eight months earlier on suspicion of being a Chinese spy.

The pigeon was detained by police in Mumbai after it was found in May with two rings on its legs bearing Chinese script, and one of the rings was found to contain a microchip.

Detectives had the pigeon held at the Bai Sakarbai Dinshaw Petit Hospital for Animals on suspicion of being involved in espionage on behalf of China.

The pigeon was turned over to the Bombay Society for the Prevention of Cruelty to Animals and set free on Tuesday.

(AP)

River knocking out power, flooding roads in California

AP
Los Angeles, Feb. 5



PHOTO: AP

Search and rescue workers investigate a car surrounded by floodwater as heavy rains caused the Guadalupe River to swell, Sunday, Feb. 4, 2024, in San Jose, Calif. The vehicle was uninhabited.

The second of back-to-back atmospheric rivers churned slowly through California early Monday, flooding roadways and knocking out power to hundreds of thousands of people and prompting a rare warning for hurricane-force winds as the already soggy state braced for another day of heavy rains.

The storm inundated streets and brought down trees and electrical lines Sunday across the San Francisco Bay Area, where winds topped 60 mph in some areas. Gusts exceeding 80 mph were recorded in the mountains.

Just to the south in San Jose, emergency crews pulled occupants out of the windows of a car stranded by floodwaters and rescued people from a homeless encampment alongside a rising river.

The storm then moved into Southern California, where officials warned of potentially devastating flooding and ordered evacuations for canyons that burned in recent wildfires that are at high risk for mud and debris flows.

Classes were cancelled Monday for schools across Santa Barbara County, which was devastated by mudslides caused by powerful storms in 2018. Further down the coast, strong winds and heavy rain brought treacherous conditions to the city of Ventura, said Alexis Herrera, who was trying to bail out his sedan which was filled with floodwater. "All the freeways are flooded around here," Herrera said in Spanish. "I don't know how I'm going to move my car."

More than 845,000 customers were without electricity statewide by Sunday evening, according to poweroutage.us.

Winds caused hours-long delays at San Francisco International Airport. By 2:30 p.m. Sunday, 155 departing flights were delayed and 69 had been cancelled, according to the tracking website FlightAware. There were also delays at the airports in San Jose and Sacramento.

Palisades Tahoe, a ski resort about 200 miles (320 kilometres) northeast of San Francisco, said Sunday it was anticipating the heaviest snowfall yet this season, with accumulations of 6 inches (15 centimetres) per hour for a total of up to two feet (60 centimetres). Heavy snow was expected into Monday throughout the Sierra Nevada and motorists were urged to avoid mountain roads.

Much of the state had been drying out from the system that blew in last week, causing flooding and dumping welcome snow in mountains. The latest storm, also called a "Pineapple Express" because its plume of moisture stretches back across the Pacific to near Hawaii, arrived offshore in Northern California on Saturday, when most of the state was under some sort of wind, surf or flood watch.

The weather service issued a rare "hurricane force wind warning" for the Central Coast, with wind gusts of up to 92 mph (148 kph) possible from the Monterey Peninsula to the northern section of San Luis Obispo County.

TODAY IN HISTORY

1579 – The Archdiocese of Manila is made a diocese by a papal bull with Domingo de Salazar being its first bishop.

1806 – Battle of San Domingo: British naval victory against the French in the Caribbean.

1819 – The Treaty of Singapore was signed by Sir Thomas Stamford Raffles, Hussein Shah of Johor, and Temenggong Abdul Rahman, and it is now recognised as the founding of modern Singapore.

1840 – Signing of the Treaty of Waitangi, establishing New Zealand as a British colony.

1843 – The first minstrel show in the United States, The Virginia Minstrels, opens (Bowery Amphitheatre in New York City).

1900 – The Permanent Court of Arbitration, an international arbitration court at The Hague, is created when the Senate of the Netherlands ratifies an 1899 peace conference decree.

EC BEGINS UPDATING VOTER LIST FOR BY-ELECTION

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 5

The Election Commission (EC) is preparing to hold by-elections for the vacant posts in the House of Representatives, Provincial Assembly and local levels. Issuing a press statement on Monday, Spokesperson at the EC Shaligram Sharma Paudel informed that 23 posts in various levels have remained vacant.

According to the EC, the by-elections will be held to elect one member of the House of Representatives, one member of the Provincial Assembly, one deputy mayor, one chairman, two vice-chairpersons and 17 ward chairmen in rural municipalities and municipalities.

The post of the member of the House of Representatives remained vacant after Subas Nembang elected from Ilam-2 passed away while the post of a Provincial Assembly has remained vacant in Sudurpashmi after Prithvi Bahadur Singh elected from Bajhag 1 (A) died in an accident in June last year.

The EC on Monday urged the voters of the constituencies, local levels and wards where the by-elections will be held to register their names in the voters' list if they were missing before the EC announces the dates for the by-elections.

UML PREPARING TO PLAY STRONG ROLE IN PARLIAMENT

RSS
Kathmandu, Feb 5

The CPN (UML) Parliamentary Party has issued a whip to the UML lawmakers to mandatorily attend the parliament's meetings and to play effective role in the winter session of the federal Parliament. The winter session is commencing from 4 pm today.

Whip of the party Mahesh Bartaula said this directive has been issued in line with the decision that the party's meeting made on Sunday. As he said, the UML will shoulder the role of the main opposition party in a stronger and effective manner in the meetings of the current session compared to the past.

The meeting of the parliamentary party has also instructed its lawmakers to play an effective role in the context of making the laws required for constitution implementation, social justice, good governance, prosperity and national interest.

Similarly, the meeting has urged the government to stop the youth brain drain to foreign countries and to promptly bring back home the Nepali youths who are in difficulty, paying attention to the deteriorating peace and security situation in West Asia.



PHOTO: RSS

Workers are busy constructing a drain and retaining wall along a road linking Bhakimli and Ratnechaur-Bhakunde in Myagdi district.

Police mainly to blame for airport assault: Report

BY PURUSHOTTAM P. KHATRI
Kathmandu, Feb. 5

The investigation of the Ministry of Home Affairs into the two-side brawl between immigration officials and Nepal Police stationed in the Tribhuvan International Airport has pointed out weaknesses on part of the leadership of Nepal Police.

There was a brawl between the officials of the Nepal Police personnel and the immigration officer of the TIA at the international departure section of the airport on January 26.

Chief Immigration Officer Gogan Bahadur Hamal, who went to inquire about the incident, was also assaulted in the CC camera control room.

Although the fight took place between the immigration officer and an assistant sub-inspector of the airport, the investigation report drew a conclusion that the situation occurred because the leadership of Nepal Police has failed to teach discipline, maintain proper conduct, professional modesty and official responsibility.

In addition, the report also mentioned that there is serious mistrust between the agencies involved in the security and management of the airport (immigration).

Rajesh Nath Bastola, Deputy Inspector General of Nepal Police, and Kul Bahadur GC, and Under Secretary of Border and Immigration Administration Section, were members of the probe committee formed under the coordination of Home Ministry's Joint Secretary Thaneshwar Gautam. The committee was formed on January 27 and was given one-week deadline to write and submit report on the incident to the Home Ministry.

"From the overall incident description, on-site study, inquiries, discussions and statements with the officials, it appears that serious mistrust has arisen in the airport between the two agencies," it is written in the conclusion section of the report.

It is further stated in the report, "From outer surface, even though the incident seemed to be an outcome of mistrust between the two officials of Nepal Police and Immigration Department, especially between Chhayan Moktan and ASI Sanjaya Tamang, it cannot be ignored that their leadership has not instilled enough discipline, conduct, professional courtesy and official responsibility."

Questioning the leadership of the police in particular, the report further stated, "Instead of taking action according to the professional conduct of the person who was held under suspicion, the police resorted to violence and beat the immigration official and in places where there are no CC cameras, they resorted to destroying evidence of the video footage of beating the immigration officials." When the police administration themselves resort to such violence, how can general public can trust in the security and behaviour of police? it was questioned in the report.

The investigation committee has pointed out that the police personnel could not give due regard to the immigration officer who was senior to them and the immigration officer also fail to behave properly with the police.

Terming the incident unfortunate, the committee has suggested 10-point recommendations to prevent such incidents from recurring in the future.

Among the 10-point recommendations, the number 10 point has suggested the government that as the DIG and Chief of the TIA Security Arjun Chand has raised very critical issues in the media after the formation of the committee, the Home Ministry should keep his statement into account he had given to the media.

The report has also recommended the Ministry to draw special attention of Nepal Police Headquarters regarding the police's lack of professional conduct, coordination and discipline.

DIG Chand has also tendered his resignation from the post on February 3, the day when the report was drafted and finalised.

Artistes' creations spread nat'l identity: President Paudel

RSS
Kathmandu, Feb 5

President Ramchandra Paudel has asserted that Nepal's rural life and originality should be developed, expanded and preserved in Nepali music.

The President said so while addressing the Natikaji National Music Honour and Prize Distribution ceremony organized by Natikaji Memorial Society at the Office of President, Sheetal Niwas, in Kathmandu today.

President Paudel expressed that Nepali music boasts of a wide array of musical instruments of various indigenous communities, original and specific tune, own context of music, and the Nepali national music was developed on its foundation.

"Creations of artistes are national heritages, cultures are national identity and artistes are precious treasures," observed the President, adding, "Artistes are catalyst for creation and culture. The creations of artistes establish identity of any nation."

Stating that the geographical diversity and cultural uniqueness of Nepal stood as its distinct identity in the world, he viewed that Nepal's diverse ethnicities, languages and cultures are unique in the world.

According to him, the diversity of Nepali society has helped unite the folk culture, songs and music.

The Head of the State reminisced that the contribution made by late musician Natikaji Shrestha in creation of modern song and music following the folk music and tune was incomparable.

He held the view that it was a matter of national interest to give due importance to the artistes who dedicate their whole lives in the sector of Nepal's music sector.

On the occasion, Society's President Shambhujeet Banskota remarked that the honour from the President had further encouraged the art sector. Suggesting that the State should institute prize in the name of artistes to motivate new talents, he emphasized a 'good' law to ensure that the artists' creation are not pirated and they get due royalty.

On the occasion, President Paudel conferred Natikaji National Special Honour on lyricists Ananda Adhikari, Bhusan Kharel, Sunil Thapa, Ram Bhattarai and Basanta Bityasi Thapa, on musicians Keshav Sunam, Dharma Munikar, Kumar Singh and Suvarna Limbu and signer Sudesh Sharma.

Similarly, feted on the occasion with Natikaji National Music Award for their special contribution to Nepal's music and songs were lyricist Bijay Shivakoti, musician Rajanraj Shivakoti and singers Sishir Yogi and Banika Pradhan.

Likewise, the Natikaji National Talent Award was distributed to singer Sanjay Tumrok, Rachana Rimal, musician Shishir Bikram Thapa and song recorder Prakash Mishra. The President presented folk singer Amrit Khati with Natikaji National Folk Music Award and Natikaji National Art Journalism to journalists Shanti Priya and Krishna Bhattarai.

Lawmakers say NA does not belong to 'Lords' and 'Kin'

RSS
Kathmandu, Feb. 5

National Assembly (NA) members aired their views in the 15th session of the NA that started today at the Federal Parliament Building in New Baneshwor.

Calling for unity among political parties to further strengthen federal democratic republic system, Jaga Prasad Sharma said that the State should seriously consider to those raising questions about existing governance system.

"The relevance of the National Assembly has been raised by showing minor weaknesses. It is not the assembly of the Lords of the Britain nor is it the House of Kin. It is the permanent assembly that is envisaged by the constitution and elected by the local and provincial representatives," he argued, pressing for the need to proving the relevance and meaningfulness of the NA.

Likewise, NA Member Devendra Dahal blamed that irregularities have spiked in the country although the incumbent government initiated the campaign for good-governance, social justice and economic prosperity.

He also accused the government of failing to take actions against those involved in big scams of corruption and misappropriation in cooperatives organizations.

Similarly, NA Member Rameshjung Rayamajhi viewed that the major opposition party had stoked frustration among the people. Calling for everyone's cooperation to make the incumbent government a success, he underscored creating an enabling environment for job creation and self-employment to reduce brain drain from the country.

Jayanti Rai drew the attention of the government towards formulation of laws related to implementation of constitution. She demanded stern actions against those encroaching or taking over the public land.

Mrigendra Kumar Singh Yadav emphasized that the current session of the NA should conclude all Bills related to transitional justice.

Tul Prasad Bishwakarma argued that the monarchy could not be an alternative to the current governance system and opined that the government should be more responsible in addressing the needs of the public.

Pakistan's election looks more like a coronation or a sure bet

AP
Islamabad, Feb. 5

Pakistan is holding parliamentary elections this week but many voters are disillusioned and wonder if the balloting can bring any real change in a country mired in political feuding, a seemingly intractable economic crisis and resurgent militancy.

Forty-four political parties will compete on Thursday for a share of the 266 seats in the National Assembly, or the lower house of parliament, with an additional 70 seats reserved for women and minorities.

After the election, the new parliament will choose the country's next prime minister. If no party wins an outright majority, then the one with the biggest share of assembly seats can form a coalition government.

Many experts agree that in Pakistan's political landscape today, there really seems to be only one top contender for the post of premier — Nawaz Sharif, a three-times former prime minister who has returned to the country and been absolved of past convictions.

Sharif came back last October after four years of self-imposed exile in London to avoid serving prison sentences. Within weeks of his return, his sentences were thrown out and his convictions overturned.

His archrival, former Prime Minister Imran Khan, a cricket hero turned Islamist politician who was ousted in April 2022, is behind bars and banned from contesting the vote.

And although Khan has a significant grassroots following, it's the intensity of his downfall and the ease of Sharif's return that have led many to believe the outcome has been already decided.

Nuclear-armed Pakistan is the fifth most populous country in the world and an unpredictable Western ally. It borders Afghanistan, China, India and Iran — a region rife with hostile boundaries and tense relations.

For the international community, a strong and stable Pakistani government means a better chance of containing any unrest, addressing economic challenges and stemming illegal migration.

And though anything can happen on election day, both Sharif's Pakistan Muslim League and Khan's Pakistan Tehreek-e-Insaf have led lackluster campaigns over the past few weeks — something experts say only feeds into the general apathy among some 127 million eligible voters.

That could come back to haunt Pakistan's next government and set the stage for an even more intense brain drain and more political trouble ahead, as well as violent protests. And that in turn would only benefit Islamic militants.

Khan's May 2023 arrest triggered destructive rampages on a scale unseen since the 2007 assassination of former Prime Minister Benazir Bhutto.

Minister Sharma urges Telecom to provide quality...

Stating that the Ministry has initiated both policy and administrative work to eliminate wrong practices and confusion in the field of telecommunication, she said that the government has amended the law to manage the assets of companies whose licenses have been revoked, and investigated and took reports on the Ncell share purchase and sale issues.

She said the new frequency policy, 2080, has been implemented to further organise the telecommunications sector.

On the occasion, Secretary of the Ministry of Communication and Information Technology and Chairman of the Board of Directors, Ramakrishna Subedi said that the NT should continue to provide quality services while maintaining good corporate governance.

Subedi stressed improving the decision-making process, working methods and institutional structure and making the internal working environment sound and effective is a must for the enhancement of the company.

Acting Chairman of Nepal Telecommunications Authority Nabaraj Adhikari said that Nepal Telecom has played an important role in the development and expansion of telecommunication services in Nepal and the company needed to be reformed as per the need of the hour.

Sangita Pahadee (Aryal), Managing Director of Nepal Telecom, said that the NT was continuously increasing its customer base after the company launched mobile and data services based on wireless 4G LTE technology in all 77 districts of the country and FTTH services based on optical fibre in 74 districts.

Stating that the company has provided various concessions for the earthquake-affected areas, she said that ICT labs would be established in various community schools, FTTH data and Namaste WiFi would be provided in government and community schools.

On the occasion of its anniversary, the NT has launched various offers for its customers.

Nepal Airlines Corporation (NAC)
Kantipath, Kathmandu Nepal

Request for Proposal
FOR THE WET LEASE OF *TWO NARROW BODY AIRCRAFT*

International Competitive Bidding (ICB)
Single-Stage: Two Envelope Bidding Procedure

Date of Publication: 6th Feb, 2024
Last date of Submission: 22nd March, 2024

Nepal Airlines Corporation (NAC) invites interested Aircraft Manufacturing Companies, Airlines Operators, and Aircraft Leasing Companies to submit their sealed bid document for the wet lease of two narrow body aircraft. The sealed bid document must reach at Corporate Department, Nepal Airlines Corporation, Kantipath, Kathmandu, Nepal within 22nd March 2024 (12:00 hrs Nepalese standard time). The sealed bid document received after last date and time of submission shall not be accepted. For more details, please visit NAC's website:

http://www.nepalairlines.com.np/home/notices

NAC reserves all rights to accept or reject all or any bid document received without giving any reason whatsoever.

Nepal Airlines Corporation (NAC)
Kantipath, Kathmandu, Nepal

RE-TENDER NOTICE
FOR
AUCTION SALE OF TWO MA-60 & THREE Y-12 E AIRCRAFT
ON
"AS IS WHERE IS BASIS"

First Date of Publication: 21 December, 2023
Second date of Publication: 6 February, 2024

Nepal Airlines Corporation (NAC) invites all interested companies and individuals to submit their sealed tender document for the Auction Sale of Two MA-60 & Three Y-12 E Aircraft on "as is where is basis". The sealed tender document must reach at Corporate Department, Nepal Airlines Corporation, Kantipath, Kathmandu, Nepal within 21st February 2024 (13:00 hrs Nepalese standard time). The sealed tender document received after last date and time of submission shall not be accepted. For more details, please visit NAC's website:

http://www.nepalairlines.com.np/home/notices

NAC reserves all rights to accept or reject all or any tender document received without giving any reason whatsoever.

Menuka Poudel welcomed in her hometown

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 5



Menuka Poudel has been eliminated from the Indian television reality show 'Indian Idol'.

She was eliminated from the final 10 of Indian Idol season 14 on Sunday.

Menuka has also announced through her social network that her Indian Idol journey is over.

"My Indian Idol journey has ended here. But, the musical journey of my life has just begun. I want to assure everyone that I will be able to entertain everyone through singing and performing even better than before. This is my beginning, not the end."

She made her debut in the Indian film 'Salaar' as a playback singer during the show. She stood out as one of the most talked-about and beloved contestants on the show.

Leaving no stone unturned, she consistently amazed not only the judges including Shreya Ghoshal, Kumar Sanu, and Vishal Dadlani but also the show's guests.

Renowned Bollywood actor Ranbir Kapoor, bowing his head, referred to her as the 'goddess of voice' in one of the episodes.

Menuka mentioned that she would be busy with films, recording, and concert singing for the next one year.

She urged her fans to support her in singing, recording, and concerts of the film.

She also mentioned that she has musical plans in her pipeline throughout this year. After the elimination, Poudel returned to her home town in Jhapa on Monday.

Upon her arrival, Haldibari Rural Muni ipality welcomed her with much fane fare.

She was honoured with cash prize of Rs. 60,000 by the rural municipality, mentioning that singer Poudel recognised the identity of the country to the international area. Rural Municipality chairman Rabindra Lindgen and vice chairman Laxmi Mainali welcomed her.

Speaking at the programme, singer Poudel said that the winning was not only her but of all the people who love music.

Art workshop of Nepali, German artistes begins

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 5



A two-day 'International Art Workshop 2024' has begun at the Nepal Academy of Fine Arts with the participation of artists from Nepal and Germany.

The workshop was jointly inaugurated by the Chancellor of the Academy, Naradamani Hartamchhali, and the German artist Helge Achenbach on Monday.

Hartamchhali expressed his gratitude to the artists who came to Nepal from Germany, adding that the present world was like a global village.

He said, "When Nepal and Germany engage in such activities, it sends a positive message by increasing the affinity between the two countries. It is necessary to continue such activities in the future."

German artist Helge Achenbach said that he was happy to come to Nepal as a guest and mentioned that he would encourage other German artists to visit Nepal as well. He said, "We also want to welcome Nepali artists to Germany."

Stating that Nepali art will be spread through such programmes, he expressed eagerness to see the work prepared during the two-day workshop.

Speaking at the event, Sanjay Bantawa Rai, head of the Contemporary Painting Department of the Academy, said that the painting workshop would contribute greatly to the exchange of art and culture between Nepal and Germany.

Nepali artists including Naradamani Hartmchhali, Lalkaji Lama, Devendra Kumar Kafle 'Thumkeli', Palsangmo Lama, Pradip Adhikari, Sauraganga Darshandhari, Dineshwar Mahato, Sanjay Bantawa, Aruna Hingmang, Sangi Shrestha, Jupiter Pradhan, Mukesh Malla, Keshav Raj Khanal and Mukesh Shrestha are participating in the workshop.

Similarly, German artists such as Botti Hans-Hermann Bottenbruch, Helge Achenbach, Alexandra B.C. Bottenbruch, Alexander Eliezer, Elaus Fottinger, Bernd Zimmer, Daniel Zerbst, Carsten Fock, Armin Baumgarten, and Susanne Kamps participated in a two-day art workshop alongside Nepali artists.

These German artists have arrived in Nepal as part of the Nepal Art Exchange prgramme.

The workshop is scheduled to conclude on Tuesday.

Litterateurs felicitated



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Lalitpur, Feb. 5

Three writers were felicitated by the World Nepali Literature Federation Lalitpur branch at a function organised in Lagankhel recently.

Poets Ramnath Adhikari Sangee and Neera Shrestha were felicitated with poetry honour while Rajesh Man KC received science literature honour.

Academician and chief of Nepal Academy Poetry Department Baba Basnet and chairman of Jyoti Literature Academy Maniraj Singh handed over the letters of honour plaques to them.

Appreciation letter to Buddhi Bikash Mandal Library and certificates to the new members of the branch were also distributed at the function.

Applauding the campaign of the organisers, academician Basnet requested to not spread disappointment among people.

'We should talk about hope that leads us to the bright days ahead,' she urged.

Poet Maniraj Singh said that the Lalitpur branch of the Federation has done much more in a very short period.

Chairman of the Lalitpur branch of the Federation Buddhiman Maharjan shed light on the activities of the branch. Sudha Mishra, general secretary of the branch, listed out the plans.

At the function, poets including Baba Basnet, Maniraj Singh, Juman Kiran, Toyanath Subedi, Chinimaya Majhi, Shree Ram Paudel, Pushpaj KC, Shekhar Acharya, Neera Shrestha, Sudha Mishra, Budhdiman Maharjan and others recited their poems.

VIGNETTES

FILM HALLS SHUT

Kathmandu (RSS): Cinema halls across the country were closed on Monday as the Nepal Motion Picture Association, the umbrella organisation of film halls, demanded the cancellation of impractical taxes imposed by the government. The Association alleges that the government has compelled the film sector to bear a tax burden exceeding 33 per cent under various tax categories.

Following the implementation of value-added tax and corporate tax, additional taxes were imposed against the policy of non-imposing other taxes. The Association shut down all movie theatres nationwide on Monday as a symbolic protest, urging the government to reconsider the impractical taxes, including film development fees and local fees.

VYATHIT LITERARY HONOUR TO THREE POETS

Kathmandu (RSS): The Literary Journalists Association has honoured three contemporary poets – Shrawan Mukarung, Krishu Chhetri and Gita Karki.

Former Chancellor of Nepal Academy and senior poet Bairagi Kainla, handed the Vyathit Literary Honour for the Year 2075 BS to Mukarung, for the year 2077 BS to Chhetri and for the year 2079 BS to Karki amidst a programme organised here today.

On the occasion, senior poet Kainla, Association president Radheshyam Lekali and honoured poets had put their views.

Taylor wins album of the year at the Grammy Awards

AP
Los Angeles, Feb. 5



Taylor Swift won album of the year at the Grammy Awards for "Midnights," breaking the record for most wins in the category with four.

She began her speech by thanking her producer and friend Jack Antonoff and added, "I would love to tell you this is the happiest moment of my life," she told the crowd, but said she feels this happy when she creates music and plays shows.

Earlier in the night, Taylor Swift used her 13th Grammy win on Sunday to announce her new album, "The Tortured Poets Department," will arrive April 19.

"I know that the way that the Recording Academy voted is a direct reflection of the passion of the fans," she said while accepting the best pop vocal album award.

"So, I want to say thank you to the fans by telling you a secret that I've been keeping from you for the last two years."

One of the night's biggest awards, record of the year, went to Miley Cyrus for "Flowers," her second-ever Grammy and second of the night.

"This award is amazing. But I really hope that it doesn't change anything because my life was beautiful yesterday," she said in her speech.

Victoria Monét won best new artist. "Thank you to the champagne-servers tonight," Monét began her acceptance speech. "Thanks to my mom, a single mom raising this really bad girl." Then she started to cry, telling the room that this award was "15 years in the making."

Billie Eilish won song of the year for writing the "Barbie" hit, "What Was I Made For?" She thanked director Greta Gerwig for "making the best movie of the year."

It was just one of several standout moments from Sunday's show, hosted by Trevor Noah and broadcast live from Cypto.com Arena in downtown Los Angeles.

Karol G made Grammy history Sunday by becoming the first female performer to win best música urbana album for her blockbuster "Mañana Será Bonito" record.

"This is my first time at the Grammys," she told the audience in English. "And this is my first time holding my own Grammy."

HOROSCOPE

tarot.com

Aries: Making progress toward your goals is possible now. While the eye-catching Moon in your public 10th house aligns with abundant Jupiter in your money zone, the people around you may be surprised to see some of the bold financial .

Taurus: You may currently appreciate the stability of a friend group or community that has been part of your life for a long time. That said, you're probably not the same person you were when you first got involved.

Gemini: Receiving help to reach your goals is presently possible. Due to the perceptive Moon in your sharing sector noticing focused Saturn in your ambitious 10th house, the effort you put in is likely obvious to potential collaborators.

Cancer: A friend may currently guide you toward some needed perspective on your political or spiritual beliefs. You don't necessarily have to abandon the main tenets that provide structure to your life, but there could be a less restrictive way of viewing.

Leo: You're equipped to deliver focused effort with careful attention to detail today. As the anxious Moon in your responsible 6th house looks to inhibited Saturn in your sharing sector, you could be hoping to impress a collaborator who seems stern and hard to please.

Virgo: Bringing a close relationship out of a rut may be necessary at any moment. You possibly appreciate being able to rely on this person's stability, but sometimes you need more than that.

Libra: You're likely looking for security at this time, and your willingness to work hard could help you achieve it. That said, you shouldn't have to rely exclusively on your own effort.

Scorpio: Feeling like you're not having enough fun could weigh on you at the moment. While the connection-seeking Moon in your communication zone aligns with repressive Saturn in your 5th House of Entertainment, you might.

Sagittarius: Reining in your money worries is presently possible. While the nervous Moon in your finance zone reaches out to stable Saturn in your security sector, you could notice that you're already doing better than you thought you were.

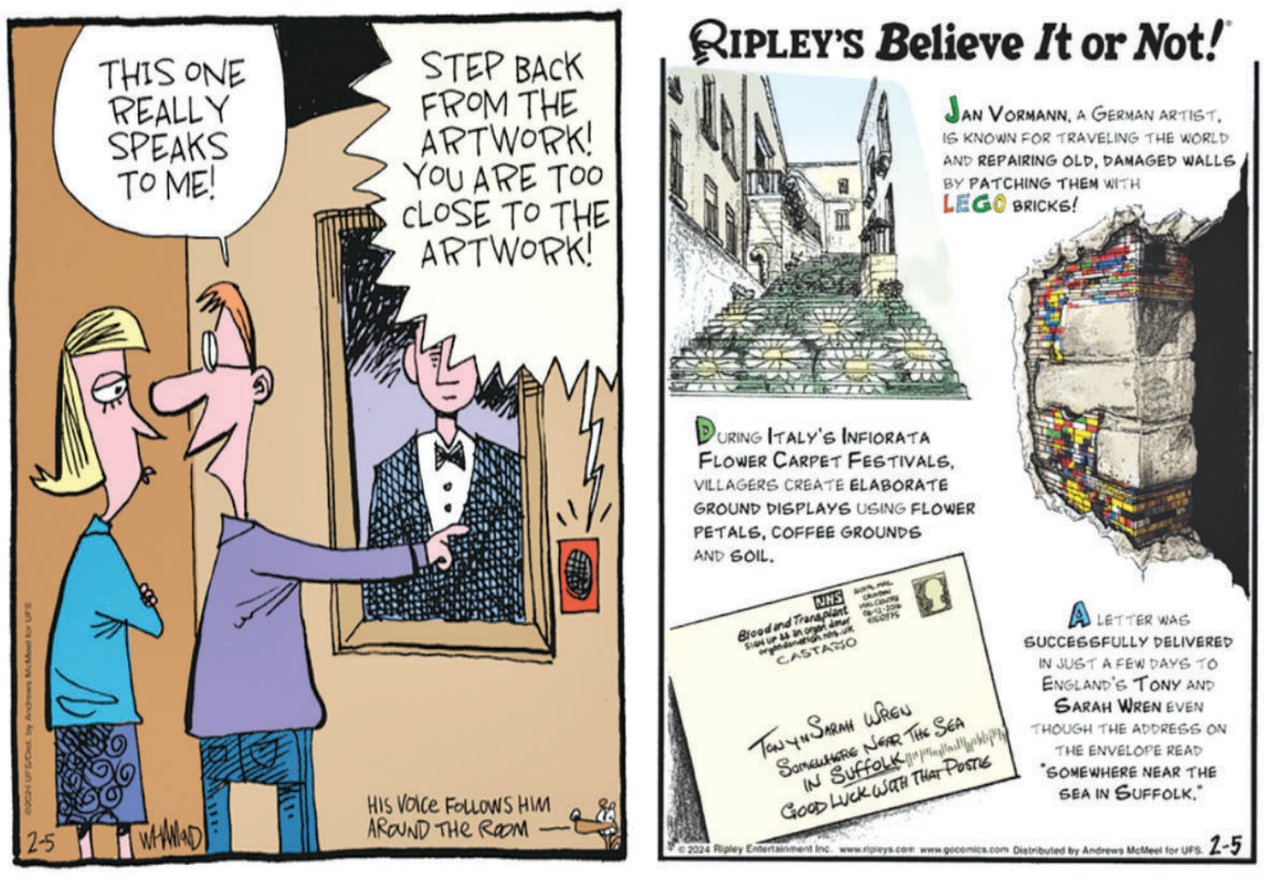
Capricorn: Your emotions are potentially close to the surface right now. While the sensitive Moon in your sign leans on solid Saturn in your communication zone, you're equipped to express your feelings in a way that you have control over.

Aquarius: Digging deeper into your roots could presently be rewarding for you. As the inquisitive Moon in your 12th House of Secrets nudges stuck Saturn in your finance sector, learning about your background.

Pisces: The chatter could currently be wild in a friend group or organization you belong to. As the impulsive Moon in your social sector connects to restrained Saturn in your sign, you might feel the need to tell others that they're being unrealistic..

CARTOON

gocomics.com



Bumrah stars as India down England to level Test series

AFP
Visakhapatnam, Feb. 5

Fast bowler Jasprit Bumrah took a match haul of nine wickets to lead India's 106-run win over England in the second Test on Monday and level the five-match series.

Chasing a record 399 for victory, England were bowled for 292 in the second session on day four in Visakhapatnam, despite an attacking start and Zak Crawley's 73.

Bumrah and spinner Ravichandran Ashwin, who ended the match on 499 Test wickets, took three each in the final innings and the pace spearhead bowled Tom Hartley to complete the win.

Shubman Gill set up the comeback victory for the hosts with his 104 on day three to set England, who won the opener, a daunting target. England came out swinging with their "Bazball" brand of cricket, Crawley and company hitting boundaries despite losing wickets. Left-arm spinner Axar Patel broke through when he trapped Rehan Ahmed lbw for 23, after the nightwatchman hit five fours in his 31-ball knock.

Ollie Pope hammered five boundaries in his brief stay at the wicket, before Ashwin had him caught at slip on 23.

Joe Root showed no signs of the finger injury which kept him out of the field for much of Sunday as he reverse-swept for two fours.

But he fell for 16 while attempting a slog off Ashwin, who remains one away from entering the 500-wicket club.

The chase soon lost steam with two wickets in five balls before lunch, including Crawley out lbw off left-arm wrist spinner Kuldeep Yadav. The lbw appeal was turned down by the on-field umpire but India successfully reviewed the call.

Jonny Bairstow followed just four balls later, with England at 194-6. Captain Ben Stokes attempted to get the chase back on track after lunch, but a direct hit by Shreyas Iyer had the left-hander run out on 11 after he looked to steal a quick single.

Wicketkeeper-batsman Ben Foakes (36) and the left-handed Hartley (also 36) put on a stubborn stand of 55 but Bumrah broke through to get Foakes caught and bowled.

But the Three Lions stuck to their fearless style, which has got them 14 wins in 20 matches under coach Brendon McCullum, nicknamed "Baz", and Stokes.

Bumrah played a key role with his six wickets in England's first-innings total of 253 as the tourists conceded a crucial lead of 143.

Veteran England pace bowler James Anderson finished with a match haul of five wickets to take his tally to 695 in a glittering Test career, which began in 2003.

The third Test starts February 15 in Rajkot and the teams will take a break beforehand, with England expected to fly to the United Arab Emirates for the week.



PHOTO: AP

India's Jasprit Bumrah celebrates the wicket of England's wicketkeeper Ben Foakes after taking his catch on the fourth day of the second cricket test match between India and England in Visakhapatnam, India, Monday.

10-wicket win for Sri Lanka

Left-arm spinner Prabath Jayasuriya finished with eight wickets in the match to lead Sri Lanka to an emphatic 10-wicket win in the only test against Afghanistan, wrapping up the victory on the fourth day Monday.

Angelo Mathews (141) and Dinesh Chandimal (107) formed Sri Lanka's backbone in the fist innings which helped them score 439 runs and take a 241 run lead.

Afghanistan made 198 in the first innings and was bowled out for 296 in the second, giving Sri Lanka a target of 56 runs to win. Dimuth Karunaratne (32 not out) and Nishan Madushka (22 not out) knocked the target easily in the eighth over.

Earlier, the tourists crumbled from their strong start to reach 252-7 at lunch, having started the day on 199-1. Ibrahim Zadran made 114 for Afghanistan, his maiden test century.

Afghanistan started the day needing 42 runs to cover the deficit and hoping to build a fighting score, after Ibrahim Zadran and Noor Ali Zadran (47) had shared a century stand, their highest for the first wicket.

After Noor Ali's departure, Ibrahim had put on an unbeaten 93 runs for the second wicket with Rahmat Shah. But inexperienced tourists failed to build on that momentum.

Fast bowler Kasun Rajitha, who was called up as a concussion substitute for Chamika Gunasekara, had the first breakthrough after Sri Lanka took the second new ball as he had Shah caught behind by Sadeera Samarawickrama for 54 runs. It was Shah's second half-century of the match, having top-scored with 91 runs in the fist innings.

Jayasuriya took 5-107, his seventh five-wicket haul and finished the game with 8-174 on a batting friendly pitch.

SNIPPETS

TU bags six gold medals

Kathmandu (TRN); The maiden University Sports Games began in Kathmandu on Monday with Tribhuvan University (TU) dominating the first day with six gold medals. TU athletes Sherbahadur Adhikari and Rajyalaxmi Rawal won gold medals in the men's and women's 1500-meter races respectively, held at Dasharath Stadium. Diwas Regmi and Sanchita Ghimire also won gold medals for TU in the men's and women's long jump categories. TU secured its sixth gold medal in table tennis, thanks to Rajojman Dhuku and Aditya Dhauniya, who won the men's doubles final. Sudurpaschim University obtained a gold medal as Mukesh Bista won the men's 400-meter race, while TU's Anamika Devkota clinched the women's gold medal in the 400-meter race.

Llorente snatches Atletico late draw

Madrid (AFP): Marcos Llorente headed home in the 93rd minute to snatch Atletico Madrid a 1-1 draw at La Liga leaders and bitter rivals Real Madrid on Sunday. The Spain midfielder rescued a point to keep Atletico's faint title hopes alive and stop Los Blancos opening up a wider lead on second-placed Girona. Brahim Diaz, who replaced the hurt Vinicius Junior just before the game, opened the scoring for Madrid at the Santiago Bernabeu. Llorente's leveller means Madrid are two points clear of Girona, who drew against Real Sociedad on Saturday, and 10 points above Atletico in fourth.

Inter takes control of Serie A

Milan (AFP): Inter Milan took firm control of the Serie A title race by winning Sunday's highly-anticipated clash with Juventus 1-0 and moving four points clear of their closest rivals for the Scudetto. Simone Inzaghi's side prevailed in a tense but eventful clash at the San Siro thanks to Federico Gatti's own goal eight minutes before half-time. Khvicha Kvaratskhelia struck a wonder goal to fire ailing champions Napoli to a morale-boosting 2-1 win over struggling Verona. Walter Mazzarri's side are seventh and were temporarily a single point away from Italy's Champions League positions until fourth-placed Atalanta beat Lazio 3-1.

New York/New Jersey to host 2026 FIFA World Cup final

Paris (AFP): The 2026 World Cup final will be held at MetLife Stadium in New York/New Jersey, organisers FIFA announced on Sunday. The New York bid held off a strong challenge from Dallas to secure the July 19 game, the culmination of the expanded 48-team tournament being co-hosted by the USA, Canada and Mexico.

The competition will kickoff with the opening game at Mexico City's iconic Azteca Stadium on June 11. Atlanta and Dallas will host the semi-finals while the third-place game will be played in Miami. The quarter-final games will take place in Los Angeles, Kansas City, Miami and Boston. A total of 16 cities across the three countries will host games with the bulk of the matches being held in the USA.

Nepali U19 team returns home



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 5

The Nepali U19 cricket team, led by Skipper Dev Khanal, returned to Kathmandu on Monday after participating in the ICC U19 World Cup held in South Africa. The team won only one match against Afghanistan in group stage, which qualified them for the Super Six stage. However, they were at the receiving end against Bangladesh and the Indian U19 team in the Super Six stage. Nepal also lost against New Zealand and Pakistan in group stage.

Khanal described the World Cup as a great learning opportunity for his team, adding that they played well overall. He singled out Aakash Chand, Subash Bhandari and Arjun Kumal for their impressive performances, but admitted that senior national team member Gulshan Jha struggled with batting. Although Jha did well in the bowling department, Khanal was disappointed to see him not shine with the bat in the World Cup.

Jha, on the other hand, was happy with his performance, as he did well in the bowling department. He acknowledged that there will always be ups and downs in the game and that it is impossible to always perform well. Coach Jagat Tamata praised his team's overall performance and expressed confidence in the future of Nepali cricket, as he believes the U19 team has some promising players.

Ravindra's 240 puts NZ on top

AP
Mount Maunganui Feb. 5

Rachin Ravindra finally caught up with his reputation on Monday, scoring 240 before New Zealand was all out for 511 on the second day of the first cricket test against South Africa. South Africa was in trouble at 80-4 at stumps, trailing by 431 runs. Kyle Jamieson took two wickets within three balls in the 10th over as South Africa slumped to 30-3 early.

David Bedingham (not out 29) and Zubayr Hamza put on 44 for the fourth wicket but Hamza was out close to stumps, bowled by Mitchell Santner.

In only his fourth test and seventh innings three years after his debut, Ravindra arrived in test cricket with a maiden century in the company of his idol Kane Williamson.

Williamson couldn't go on Monday, falling at 118 at the end of a 232-run third-wicket partnership. Ravindra went on to 150 and then to 200 from 340 balls, becoming the second-youngest New Zealander after Matthew Sinclair to score a double century and the third New Zealander to turn a maiden hundred into 200. Sinclair and Martin Donnely are the others.

In another extraordinary milestone Monday, South Africa captain Brand took 6-119 on test debut. Brand is only a part-time left-arm spinner and likely would not have expected to bowl with four seamers in the tourists' lineup.

WEATHER

Tuesday

Sunrise at 6:48 am, Sunset at 5:48 pm

Forecast for Nepal (Tuesday)

Partly cloudy in the hilly areas of Koshi Province, Gandaki Province, Karnali Province and Sudur Pashchim Province and mainly fair in rest of the country. Chances of light snowfall at one or two places of the high hilly and mountainous region of Koshi Province, Gandaki Province, Karnali Province and Sudur Pashchim Province.

Expected Temp.: 18-20 Rain Probability: 0%

Monday's Weather Record

Stations	Max. temp. (C)	Min. temp. (C)	Rain (mm)
Dipayal	23.2	8.4	0.1
Dadeldhura	16.2	3.5	0.2
Dhangadi	22.8	10.2	0.3
Birendranagar	21.4	7.7	0.0
Nepalgunj	22.4	11.0	0.2
Jumla	14.5	-3.5	0.0
Ghorahi	19.1	8.5	0.0
Pokhara	21.4	11.4	0.0
Bhairahawa	22.2	9.5	0.0
Simara	22.7	12.5	0.0
Kathmandu	19.8	6.7	0.0
Okhaldhunga	17.2	6.0	0.0
Taplejung	13.8	6.4	0.0
Dhankuta	18.2	9.8	0.0
Biratnagar	23.7	13.0	0.0
Jomsom	10.0	-3.5	0.0*
Dharan	23.5	14.5	Traces*
Lumle	14.5	6.1	0.0*
Janakpur	26.0	13.5	0.0*
Jiri	16.7	0.8	0.0*

NEPAL RASTRA BANK

FOREIGN EXCHANGE DEPARTMENT

EXCHANGE RATES

February 6, 2024

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
Indian Rupee	100	Rs. 160.00	Rs. 160.15

Open Market Exchange Rates
For the purpose of Nepal Rastra Bank

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
U.S. Dollar	1	Rs. 132.60	Rs. 133.20
Euro	1	Rs. 142.62	Rs. 143.27
Pound Sterling	1	Rs. 166.92	Rs. 167.68
Swiss Franc	1	Rs. 152.60	Rs. 153.29
Australian Dollar	1	Rs. 86.26	Rs. 86.65
Canadian Dollar	1	Rs. 98.34	Rs. 98.78
Singapore Dollar	1	Rs. 98.55	Rs.98.99
Japanese Yen	10	Rs. 8.94	Rs. 8.98
Chinese Yuan	1	Rs. 18.42	Rs. 18.51
Saudi Arab Riyal	1	Rs. 35.36	Rs. 35.52
Qatari Riyal	1	Rs. 36.37	Rs. 36.54
Thai Bhat	1	Rs. 3.71	Rs. 3.73
UAE Dirham	1	Rs. 36.10	Rs. 36.27
Malaysian Ringgit	1	Rs. 27.91	Rs. 28.04
South Korean Won	100	Rs. 9.15	Rs. 10.00
Swedish Kronar	1	Rs. 12.54	Rs. 12.60
Danish Kronar	1	Rs. 19.13	Rs. 19.22
Hong Kong Dollar	1	Rs. 16.95	Rs. 17.03
Kuwaiti Dinar	1	Rs. 430.80	Rs. 432.75
Bahrain Dinar	1	Rs. 351.72	Rs. 353.32

Note: Under the present system the open market exchange rates quoted by different banks may differ.

Premier League title race gets a lot tighter

AP
London, Feb. 5

The Premier League title race just got a lot tighter. Arsenal benefited from two second-half errors from Liverpool goalkeeper Alisson Becker to claim a 3-1 victory over the league leaders on Sunday.

Arsenal moved up to second place and just two points behind Liverpool after 23 of 38 games in what might shape up to be a three-way fight for the title.

Manchester City is in third place, five points off Liverpool but with two games in hand, and the defending champions will likely be happy with the result at Emirates Stadium. City is away to Brentford on Monday.

Liverpool fell to only its second loss in the league, with the other also coming in north London — at Tottenham. If that defeat was in contentious circumstances, this one was of Liverpool's own making after being dominated for large parts of the game and because of the nature of Arsenal's crucial second goal in the 67th that made it 2-1.

Alisson, widely seen as the league's best goalkeeper, came out of his area in an attempt to clear a long pass forward but kicked fresh air and the ball hit the back of covering defender Virgil van Dijk. Gabriel Martinelli had the simple task of tapping the loose ball into an empty net.

The same Liverpool players had a role in a stoppage-time third, too, with Leandro Trossard's shot deflecting off the outstretched boot of Van Dijk and going through the legs of Alisson as he tried to make the save at his near post. Liverpool was down to 10 men at that point after Ibrahima Konate's sending off for two yellow cards.

Bukayo Saka gave Arsenal the lead in the 14th minute, only for Arsenal defender Gabriel Magalhaes to score an own-goal when the ball struck his hand and flew into the net.



That pulled Liverpool level at halftime, despite the visitors not having a shot on goal in the first half in what was a below-par display overall by the leaders.

"It just shows the boys are human beings," Klopp said. "Today we were really human."

Hojlund's Streak

Rasmus Hojlund failed to find the net in his first 14 games in the Premier League for Manchester United. Now he cannot stop scoring.

The Denmark striker marked his 21st birthday by scoring for the fourth straight league game, setting United on its way to a 3-0 win against West Ham at Old Trafford.

Alejandro Garnacho, a 19-year-old winger, netted the other two goals in the second half — and celebrated the first of them by perching on an advertising board with Hojlund and 18-year-old midfielder Kobbie Mainoo. They are three young players around whom United is building its future.

United's current level is sixth place, a point above West Ham in seventh and six points behind Tottenham in fifth.

The pressure is back on Chelsea manager Mauricio Pochettino after a second straight heavy loss in the league, this time 4-2 at home to Wolverhampton. With his team languishing in 11th place, Pochettino accepted Chelsea's players "are not matching the history of the club."

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